THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

MONDAY 9 NOVEMBER 2026 · THE HOLIDAY EDITION



IT MADE 4,815,000 FRANCS AND DID NOT BEAT ITS OWN ESTIMATE (P10)

THE GOOD LIFE

Phillips published no total for Geneva XXIV, so we added all 211 lots: CHF 91.9 million

THE RABBIT HOLE

Ice climbing opens its season after two tool recalls, with the good gear out of stock

THE TRAVEL DESK

Jaipur's great sundial is ruled to two seconds; its own shadow blurs six times wider

Source: Phillips — lot 220, The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV, catalogue photograph. Cartier Portico mystery clock, sold 8 November 2026 for CHF 4,815,000.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 157

Contents

p3 The World — six dead in Kraków, and a licence
p4 The World — a mandate, and two parties saying no
p5 Singapore — the shuttle, the girl and the question
p6 The Atelier — a pencil stops improving at $1.70
p7 Technology — a cliff moved sixty-two days
p8 The Home Lab — the price of memory, in a cupboard
p9 The Kit — the same shortage, wearing a suit
p10 The Good Life — the total Phillips would not print
p11 Screen & Sound — Godzilla takes America
p12–13 The Family Desk — a flat line; 22 minutes
p14 The Macro Desk — a rally made of expectations
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — ice climbing, recalled twice
p18 Fitness — the hand beat the legs
p19–22 The Travel Desk — six inches; a sundial
p23–24 The Diary — kabuki on Saturday; five openings
p25–27 The Long Read — the coefficient nobody sees

THE NUMBER NOBODY PUBLISHED. An auction house closed and printed no total, so this desk counted the lots (p10). Two companies will not say how many customers they lost (p5). A rule is stayed with no reason (p7). A pencil's grade means nothing in particular (p6). A platform pays by a multiplier only it can see (p26).

FROM THE DESK

"he who wisheth one day to fly, must first learn standing and walking and running and climbing and dancing:—one doth not fly into flying!"

Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spake Zarathustra*, Third Part, "The Spirit of Gravity", trans. Thomas Common[1]

For p6, where the ladder stops at a dollar seventy, and p17, where it stops at five thousand.

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.86%	▼ 5bp wk
US 10-year real[2]	2.63%	▲ 1bp wk
Implied breakeven[2]	2.23%	▼ 6bp wk
VWRA[3]	$184.98	▼ 0.70%
AGGU[3]	$5.85	▼ 0.09%
Gold[3]	$4,070	▲ ~4% wk
Bitcoin[3]	$75,662	▼ 2.60% wk
Brent[3]	$98.32	▼ 12.5% wk
USD/SGD[3]	1.2827	▲ 0.41%
Straits Times[3]	5,179.17	▼ 2.21%

Singapore is shut for Deepavali observed, so Friday's close stands (p14). Bitcoin is the only line that traded this weekend, and it did almost nothing. Not advice.[3]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · MONDAY

No. 110, 22 September 2026, created the Table Ledger after a reader noticed that one restaurant had run four times in thirteen issues. The rule it wrote is still the strictest in the book: two runs, seven issues apart, then the name is spent.

Today it barred 131 venues before a single word of p24 was written, and the five that survived are there because they were checked twice — once against the ledger, once against a second source for the opening date.

Four of the first eight candidates were not new at all. A ledger cannot catch that; only a date check can. Both ran.

SOURCES 1 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spake Zarathustra: A Book for All and None*, Third Part, LV "The Spirit of Gravity", section 2, in Thomas Common's translation, **read at source in the Project Gutenberg text and quoted exactly as it stands there, archaic forms and all**. 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and real yield curve files for November 2026, read at source; **the weekly change is measured Monday 2 November to Friday 6 November, and the breakeven line is this desk's subtraction of the real curve from the nominal one — a proxy for, not a reading of, the published breakeven** (p14). 3 Levels at Friday 6 November's close, each read at source instrument by instrument and set out on p14. **Gold is a spot reading agreed by two independent sources and does not trade over the weekend; bitcoin trades continuously and its figure is a weekend snapshot, which is why it is the only line here that is not Friday's. The Straits Times figure is Friday's fall, taken before Wall Street rebounded, and is a timing artefact rather than a verdict.**

THE WORLD · KRAKÓW

Michał O. killed six in Kraków's market square

Three more bodies were found at his home in Ostrowiec Świętokrzyski, 150km away. Sixteen were wounded, and Donald Tusk declared two days of national mourning.

A 24-year-old Polish man fired from a car into the streets around Kraków's main market square on Saturday afternoon, killing six people, and three more bodies were found at his family home 150 kilometres to the north-east. Poland's National Prosecutor's Office said on Sunday it had opened an investigation treating the killings as a terrorist offence, and that the evidence indicated one person committed the acts in both places.[1]

It matters beyond Poland because of what the gunman was licensed to hold. He had a valid firearms permit, in a country where holding one is uncommon — and the shooting club nearest his home says he never trained there in the kind of shooting he went on to do. A licence is a promise that the state knows who is armed, and it was tested in the most photographed square in the country.[2]

The dead were three Polish women aged 47, 53 and 61; a **32-year-old British man**; a Polish man in his fifties; and a woman of 51 whose nationality has not been released. **Sixteen were wounded, eleven of them Polish**; the interior ministry says British, Austrian, German, Russian and Portuguese citizens are among the dead and injured. Two officers, **Jakub Kulik** and **Artur Morański**, were critically hurt in the firefight that ended it.[1]

He survived several operations and remains critical, which is why no charge has yet been put to him.

Poland names the suspect only as **Michał O.**, as its privacy law requires. He appears to have used a rifle of the AR-15 pattern, and police found more firearms in his car. Interior Minister **Marcin Kierwiński** said early findings indicated "very radical far-right views", while cautioning that this was unconfirmed and the motive unknown. The square stayed shut on Sunday, and the hourly trumpet call from St Mary's tower was silent for twelve hours.[3] Tusk's two days of mourning began the same morning.[3]

9

DEAD ACROSS TWO TOWNS: SIX IN KRAKÓW, THREE AT THE SUSPECT'S HOME[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT POLAND SAID ABOUT MICHAŁ O.'S LICENCE

The sharpest voice on Michał O.'s licence came from inside Poland's own shooting world. **A club in Starachowice**, near Ostrowiec Świętokrzyski, said publicly that he **had never trained there in dynamic, tactical or combat shooting** — a careful sentence that answers the question the sport will be asked all week and concedes nothing else. The **National Prosecutor's Office** announced the case on social media rather than at a podium: "the evidence indicates that the same person committed the acts" in both cities.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY KRAKÓW MAY NOT BE A TERRORISM CASE

The terrorism label was applied to Kraków within a day, before anyone had spoken to the suspect. Michał O. is critical and not formally detained, let alone interviewed; no manifesto, claim or network has been reported. The ideological reading is the interior minister's, and he said himself it was unconfirmed. The shape of the event also fits another pattern: three family members killed at home, then strangers killed in public, is the signature of a familicide rather than of an organisation. **What would settle it:** a document, a claim, or his own account if he lives to give one.[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Egypt — al-Ayyat. A Giza–Fayoum train struck the rear of a stopped Cairo–Aswan service on Sunday, derailing carriages onto a country road. The health ministry counts **at least seven dead and more than 125 injured**. Al-Ayyat is where a 2002 carriage fire killed more than 370.[4]

SOURCES 1 Notes from Poland's report of 8 November 2026, read at source, for the six Kraków dead with their ages and nationalities, the sixteen wounded and the eleven Polish among them, the interior ministry's list of nationalities, the two named officers, the firing-from-a-car detail, the AR-15-pattern rifle and the further firearms in the vehicle, the three bodies at the home and the separate Ostrowiec investigation, the suspect's critical condition and the fact that he has not been formally detained, the Starachowice club's statement, the prosecutors' quoted sentence, Tusk's mourning decree and Nawrocki's signature. 2 The licence and training point is drawn from the same report. **The familicide reading in the Sceptic is this desk's argument from the published facts, and is not a claim by any investigator.** 3 Al Jazeera's report of 8 November 2026, read at source, for the square's closure and the twelve-hour suspension of the trumpet call; that outlet also calls the suspension the first since 1939, **which is not corroborated anywhere else here and is therefore not printed as fact above.** Kierwiński's wording appears in both reports. **Reuters, the Associated Press, the Guardian and the BBC all refused this desk, and Reddit refused every desk in this issue, so no forum sentiment appears on this page.**

THE WORLD · ISRAEL

Herzog handed Eisenkot a 28-day mandate to form Israel's government

Eisenkot's alliance won 48 seats on 27 October against Netanyahu's 53. The 67 recommendations that beat him include 19 Arab-led members he has ruled out governing with.

President Isaac Herzog formally tasked Gadi Eisenkot with forming Israel's next government at a televised ceremony in Jerusalem at five o'clock on Sunday afternoon. Eisenkot, a former army chief of staff who now leads the Yashar alliance, has 28 days to assemble a majority, which Herzog may extend by 14 more. He said "now is the time for the formation of a national emergency government", and that Israel "cannot afford delay or yet another cycle of endless elections".[1]

A mandate is not a government, and the gap between them is the story. In Israel the president gives the job to whoever looks likeliest to command 61 of the Knesset's 120 seats, after each party recommends a candidate. Eisenkot collected **67 recommendations against Netanyahu's 46** — and yet he lost the election. His four parties hold 48 seats; Netanyahu's bloc holds 53. He is ahead on a show of hands and behind on the count.[1]

The arithmetic has two doors and he has been shown the back of both. **Arab-led parties won a record 19 seats**, and 19 of his 67 recommendations are theirs; Avigdor Liberman's Yisrael Beytenu, inside Eisenkot's own bloc, will not sit with them. The other door is the Haredim: **48 plus United Torah Judaism's 7 plus Shas's 6 makes 61**, by a seat. Netanyahu, who calls the result stolen, said that with a government like Eisenkot's "Israel simply won't survive".[2]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Reads the week as the Arab-led bloc's unthanked decision. Joint List member **Ahmad Tibi** called Eisenkot's mandate "expected" and said the endorsement gave him a "considerable margin", while expecting a minority government on "external support from the Arab parties" that would not be a "dream government" for them.[3]

JERUSALEM — THE TIMES OF ISRAEL

Reads it as a Haredi arithmetic problem, not a mandate story. United Torah Judaism's abstention is the hinge, Shas's refusal the obstacle, and hawks inside Eisenkot's own alliance oppose relying on Ra'am or the Joint List at all. On this reading the 67 counts who dislikes Netanyahu, not who will sit together.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT EISENKOT'S POSSIBLE PARTNERS SAID

The parties whose seats make Eisenkot's only non-Arab path to 61 spent the weekend ruling it out. **Shas publicly called reports of its cooperation "total fake news"**, saying it stays in the right-wing bloc; a Shas source on its Council of Torah Sages put it plainly — "There is no scenario in which Shas rabbis will act against United Torah Judaism rabbis."[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY EISENKOT'S 67 MAY PRODUCE NO GOVERNMENT

A recommendation is a sentence; a coalition is a signature. Strip the 19 Arab-led recommendations Eisenkot has ruled out governing with and he is on 48 against Netanyahu's 53 — the actual result. Reaching 61 needs both United Torah Judaism, which recommended nobody, and Shas, which calls the cooperation reports fake news. **What would settle it:** a signed coalition agreement inside 28 days.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Turkey — day four, still ungazetted. The *Resmî Gazete* of 9 November, issue 33425, carries no Laws section at all. The Mecca pact ratified **279–119** is absent on 6, 7, 8 and 9 November, and by its own second article it takes effect on publication.[4]

Riyadh — shrapnel, not a strike. Saudi Arabia's energy ministry said falling debris damaged an Aramco administrative building after air defences destroyed **five Houthi ballistic missiles and a drone** on Sunday, with no casualties. The ministry's own word is "attempted", and the tower's identification rests on agency reports.[5]

SOURCES 1 The Jewish Telegraphic Agency's report of 8 November 2026, read at source, for the ceremony, the 67–46 recommendation split with United Torah Judaism's seven recommending nobody, Eisenkot's quoted sentences and the 28-day mandate extendable by 14. 3 Al Jazeera's report of 7 November 2026, read at source, for Tibi's quoted remarks, the 48/53/19 seat figures from the 27 October election, Eisenkot's war-cabinet observer role and the outlet's own framing of Netanyahu's warning, which is attributed to it rather than adopted. **Chinese state media carried nothing on this story: the Global Times front page was read on 9 November and has no item on Israel, so no Beijing panel appears.** 4 The *Resmî Gazete* of 9 November 2026, issue 33425, read at source twice — the front page and the dated index — neither carrying a Kanunlar section. **Both reads were of the index rather than every item's full text, so a later repeat issue would not appear in them.** 5 Al Jazeera's reports of 8 November 2026 on the Riyadh interceptions and the Amsterdam march, read at source. **The Houthis issued no claim of responsibility in that report; the attribution is the Saudi-led coalition's.**

SINGAPORE · THE PUNGGOL TRIALS

LTA ordered Grab to pause driverless testing at Punggol junctions

A Grab shuttle running WeRide software braked and veered as a schoolgirl crossed in Punggol at 8.11am on 5 November. Its safety operator then took the wheel.

The Land Transport Authority told reporters on 6 November that Grab must stop testing autonomous vehicles at junctions like the one in Punggol where one of its driverless shuttles came close to a schoolgirl the previous morning. The pause holds until the investigation finishes, and the authority will also review whether a vehicle's response to that situation ought to change. The three public routes, which carry passengers, were not suspended.[1]

This is the first time a Singapore regulator has halted any part of the driverless programme since the shuttles began carrying the public in Punggol on 1 April. The vehicles were not on a passenger run; they were learning new routes, which is what a trial is for. What makes it a public argument rather than an engineering one is the question nobody at the junction could answer: if one of these hits a child, who pays?[2]

The authority's account of the recorded data is a sequence, and the order matters. The vehicle **detected two pedestrians and tracked their movements**; they stood still. When its light turned green it **began a left turn**. When the girl started to cross — the signal **green but blinking**, the phase already expiring — it **braked and veered right**. Then the safety operator **took manual control**, steering away from her. Nobody was hit. Grab said only that "safety is our top priority".[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT PUNGGOL SAID ABOUT THE SHUTTLE

The clip of the Punggol shuttle reached the public before the regulator did: it was posted to Facebook by **SG Road Vigilante** on 5 November. Both Singapore outlets that reported it describe a split audience rather than an outraged one — commenters who **blamed the girl for stepping out without looking**, and commenters who thought **the vehicle reacted too slowly**. One says the clip was "the talk of many Punggol chats", with parents asking who is responsible if a driverless car hits someone. **Those are the outlets' characterisations; neither quotes a named resident.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE PUNGGOL SHUTTLE BEHAVED AS DESIGNED

On the authority's own reading of the Punggol data, every layer fired in the order it was built to fire. The vehicle saw both pedestrians before it moved, tracked them, braked and steered away when one moved, and the operator aboard — who exists for exactly this — took the wheel. Nobody was touched, in either incident. Both cars were commissioning new routes without passengers, the regulator left the live services running, and the signal was already blinking. Two incidents on one morning across two operators and two software stacks is as consistent with two companies opening routes at once as with a common fault. **What would settle it:** the investigation's finding.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Indonesia calls 18 Singapore adoptions illegal. The social affairs ministry's **Kahono Agung Suhartoyo** said in Jakarta on 5 November that they "did not meet Indonesia's requirements", after a **Bandung court sentenced 13 people** for falsifying the children's residency papers. Each was reportedly sold for about **Rp300 million**. No Singapore reply exists.[3]

Day three, and still no count. Neither **M1** nor **Doctor Anywhere** has said how many customers its breach exposed. M1's release names the data taken but **no regulator**, only "the relevant authorities".[4]

SOURCES 1 Mothership's report of 7 November 2026, read at source, for the Land Transport Authority's direction to Grab, its statement that it is investigating and will review the vehicle response, the five-step account of the recorded data, the blinking pedestrian signal, Grab's quoted statement, the WeRide partnership, the 1 April 2026 start of the Punggol trial and the two-of-three route split. 2 littlebigreddot's report, read at source, for the 8.11am timing on Thursday 5 November, the school-run context, the weekend circulation on Facebook, the Punggol group chats and the parents' liability question; the divided-commenters characterisation appears in both reports. **Neither outlet quotes a named member of the public, and Reddit refused every desk in this issue.** 3 The ComfortDelGro strand is carried by an aggregator crediting Channel NewsAsia and AsiaOne. **Channel NewsAsia, The Straits Times and AsiaOne all refused this desk or carried no readable version, so it is printed as relayed rather than read at origin. A joint Singapore statement of 9 January is reported secondhand; both ministries' newsrooms returned 404 or an empty body. 4 M1's own news release of 6 November 2026 and Techgoondu's report of 7 November, both read at source.**

THE ATELIER · PENCILS

Mitsubishi's Hi-Uni is where a pencil stops getting better

It and Tombow's MONO 100 cost US$20 a dozen. Blackwing, on the same Californian cedar, is US$34 — and does not win the blind test.

A pencil is four things — a baked stick of clay and graphite, two grooved slats glued round it, the glue line, and the paint — and this page is about which of the four your money buys. Above about two dollars a pencil you are almost never buying better wood.[1]

Almost every good pencil comes from the same tree and, more surprisingly, the same mill. The wood is **incense cedar** from California and Oregon, and one American family firm saws practically all the world's pencil slats — in a factory it owns in **Tianjin, China**, where it moved production in 2001 before closing its American sawmills. American tree, Chinese mill, then shipped out to be assembled and painted.[1]

The core is where quality lives, and the makers publish the mechanism. Mitsubishi's factory walk-through: graphite and clay milled with water, pressed, extruded, dried and **fired at 1,000 to 1,200°C** — then the step that separates a smooth lead from a scratchy one, **"hot oil is soaked into the core"**. Caran d'Ache does the same with wax, soaking its leads **24 hours** across **35 steps** in Geneva. And the ladder is short: the floor at 33 to 55 US cents buys real cedar and no quality control — one reviewer testing ForestChoice found **one good pencil in three** — while **Hi-Uni and MONO 100 at US$20 a dozen** buy a denser impregnated core, seventeen grades and twelve working pencils in twelve. Above that you buy boxes, editions and plating: a Graf von Faber-Castell Perfect Pencil in platinum is **US$350**.[4][2]

And the thing nobody tells you: the grading scale is not standardised. No universal graphite-to-clay ratio sits behind the letters, so HB is a house opinion — a Japanese HB lays down about a grade darker than a German one. The luxury tier has left the scale altogether: Blackwing grades its cores "soft, balanced, firm, extra-firm", which cannot be checked against anything.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT PENCIL PEOPLE SAY ABOUT BLACKWING

The pencil grail does not win the blind test, and the people who tested it said so. Pencil Talk compared the original Eberhard Faber 602 — the dead pencil whose name Blackwing's revival bought — against modern Japanese ones, found it **"average in darkness and smoothness"** and concluded it **"isn't really a peer of the top modern pencils"**. On the gaps between the best pencils made, the same site's **Robert M.** is flat: **"the differences are rather minor." Reddit refused every desk in this issue, so there is no r/pencils voice here.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE PENCIL PREMIUM IS THEATRE

Blackwing is a Japanese pencil in a Californian wrapper with an American dead name on it, and its maker says so. The firm that owns the slat monopoly reintroduced it in 2010 with "premium Japanese graphite", sells a "Made in Japan" hat, and titles its own history page **"The story of the $40 pencil"**. Eberhard Faber registered the name in 1934 and let it lapse. The same firm sells the same cedar unbadged at **42 cents**, and its subscription is **US$125 a year** shipping "a sealed pencil archive tube" — a tube you are told not to open. **In fairness:** Caran d'Ache's £5.50 Technograph buys 35 steps and a published break test. Price is not theatre; plating is. **And in Singapore the theatre costs more:** Blackwing goes through Moleskine's local store at **S$76 a dozen**, 73 per cent above its direct price, in a market whose largest chain stocks no premium wood-cased pencil at all.[7][6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Mortar & pestle (and the suribachi) — granite against porcelain, and why grooves do the work.

Tiffin carriers & stacked lunch boxes — steel gauge, and the clasp that fails first.

Secateurs & garden hand tools — Felco, Okatsune, and a blade with spares.

SOURCES 1 California Cedar Products Company's own pages, read at source, for its description of itself as the world's leading supplier of pencil slats, for incense cedar's properties and Californian and Oregon origin, and for its own statement that all its slats are produced at its wholly owned subsidiary in Tianjin, China, with its blog dating the relocation to 2001 and the closure of its American slat and sawmill operations. 4 Prices read at source on 8 November 2026 at each maker's or retailer's page; the ForestChoice test is a named reviewer's. 5 Pencil Talk, read at source, for the Eberhard Faber comparison, the quoted conclusions and Robert M.'s comment. 7 Popular's own online catalogue, filtered in full; Fook Hing Trading's own site; Moleskine's Singapore store, all read at source on 8 November 2026; Pentel's 2003 library article on humidity, as quoted and linked by Pencil Talk, read at source. **Cat Socrates' domain is parked, Art Friend's does not resolve, Kinokuniya returned 403 and two other local shops are outside this session's network, so no claim is made about their stock.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE AFFILIATES RULE

Commerce extended its Affiliates Rule stay to 10 January 2027

The Bureau of Industry and Security published the extension on 9 November, the morning the rule was due to bite, and gave no reason for it.

The American department that decides which foreign companies may buy advanced chips has postponed, a second time, a rule that would widen those restrictions to thousands of firms — publishing the postponement on the day it was due to take effect. The notice appeared this morning, Washington time, and runs the delay to **10 January 2027**. It gives no explanation.[1]

The rule does something simple and very large. American export controls name specific companies that may not receive certain technology, and that list has a hole: a listed company can own others that are not listed. The rule closes it by extending the restriction automatically to any firm **half-owned or more** by a listed party, directly or indirectly, and even where several hold the stake between them. Thousands of subsidiaries would be caught the moment it switched on — which is why it has been switched off twice. It is published at **91 FR 70789** and signed by **Jeffrey I. Kessler**, Under Secretary for Industry and Security, as a "final rule; stay"; its abstract says the suspension "was set to end November 9, 2026" and is extended "through January 10, 2027", and the supplementary information says nothing more.[2]

Yesterday's issue recorded this rule as returning on 9 November with nothing filed to stop it. That was accurate on Friday and is wrong today: the stay had been released on **5 November**, four days before the cliff. **The correction belongs on this page.** The rule was issued on 30 September 2025 and suspended under the Busan truce; it **remains suspended rather than withdrawn**. The stay buys 62 days, and lands the expiry in the month China's rare-earth controls could resume and a Democratic-controlled Congress convenes with subpoena powers pointed at Nvidia's China sales.[2]

62

DAYS BOUGHT BY THE STAY, FROM 9 NOVEMBER TO 10 JANUARY[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE EXPORT BAR SAID ABOUT THE AFFILIATES RULE

The Affiliates Rule's community is the export-control bar, and it published inside a day. **Baker McKenzie**'s Alison J. Stafford Powell and Lise S. Test posted on **5 November**, noting that the Treasury Secretary had announced a truce extension to the same January date in September **without mentioning the rule**, "which caused some confusion"; their advice is to "continue to prepare ownership-based screening and due diligence procedures". Miller Canfield titled its note **"Suspension Extended but Uncertainty Remains"**.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE AFFILIATES RULE STAY IS NOT NEWS

The strongest case against the Affiliates Rule story is that nothing happened, for the third time. A rule never in force has again not come into force, for 62 days, on a document that states no reasoning. Nothing was conceded and nothing withdrawn; listed parties stayed restricted throughout, so no compliance burden lifted. A stay is the cheapest policy instrument there is, and reading diplomatic meaning into a date change is how a reader ends up with a thesis built on a calendar entry. The document even contradicts itself on its own history, dating the original rule to both 20 and 30 September 2025. **What would settle it:** a permanent revocation, or the rule biting in January.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Beijing is the bottleneck now, not Washington. Roughly **600,000 Nvidia H200s** are reported sitting in Hong Kong warehouses because China has not approved large-volume imports, preferring domestic silicon for inference. An eight-card server was offered on the grey market at over **¥6m** in late October, three times its price a year earlier. **A Commerce official told a House hearing that no such sale has been approved at all; the two accounts cannot both be whole.**[3]

SOURCES 1 Federal Register document 2026-22793, "Extension of the Suspension of Expansion of End-User Controls for Affiliates of Certain Listed Entities", citation 91 FR 70789, published and effective 9 November 2026, read at source through the Federal Register's own interface, for the action type, the quoted abstract sentences, the January date, the signatory and the absence of any stated reasoning, and for the internal date contradictions noted in the Sceptic. Stafford Powell and Lise S. **The contradicting Commerce testimony is a search-surfaced quotation this desk did not open, and is printed as a contradiction rather than as a finding.** 4 Seoul Economic Daily, 8 November 2026, machine-translated from Korean and itself aggregating American reporting; **nytimes.com and ft.com were not reachable, so no element of that item rests on an original read.**

TECHNOLOGY · RASPBERRY PI

Raspberry Pi raised its biggest Model 5 by eighty dollars on 2 November

Eben Upton blamed "a lack of alternative supply" for the memory it uses, promised to roll the rise back, and gave no date for doing so.

The cheapest serious computer a person can put in a cupboard to run their own house — the cameras, the heating, the music, the family's files — became a quarter more expensive on 2 November, and not because it got better. Raspberry Pi's founder, Eben Upton, said on the company blog that the memory chips it needs have no alternative supply, and that the increase will be reversed when they get cheaper. He did not say when.[1]

What makes this worth a page is who is on the other side of the shortage. The companies building data centres for artificial intelligence have bought the world's supply of memory, and when a commodity runs short the small orders go unfilled first. For the first time the hobbyist's hardware budget and the hyperscaler's capital-expenditure line are the same market, bidding for the same parts. The home-lab reader is a price-taker in an auction they are not in.[2]

The numbers, in the company's own words. "From today, we are raising the price of the 16GB variant of Raspberry Pi 5 by $80, to $385." The Compute Module variants rise **$40**; the 500+ is held. The cause given is "a lack of alternative supply for 16GB DRAM, compounded by other ongoing component shortages". Upton calls the landscape "difficult but ultimately temporary". The post does not print the old price; **$385 less $80 is $305, a rise of 26.2 per cent** — arithmetic, not a published figure.[1]

The better story is the pattern: this is the **sixth** memory-driven price action on the same blog in twelve months. In January *Tom's Hardware* reported that Raspberry Pi and mini-PC home-lab prices had reached parity as memory costs climbed. The board's whole reason for existing was that it was cheap, and that advantage has been competed away by a market it does not participate in.[3]

$385

THE 16GB RASPBERRY PI 5, FROM $305 — A RISE OF 26.2 PER CENT[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT HACKER NEWS SAID ABOUT THE $385 RASPBERRY PI

The honest report is that the reaction to the Raspberry Pi rise has been small. An Ask HN posted at **12:34 UTC on 8 November** by **haebom** — "The price of the Raspberry Pi has gone over $350. This is insane" — drew **three points and two comments**. **FrankWilhoit**: "If it's really BOM cost, it will come down after the crash", and if not, "it's an opening for someone to make a better clone." **fithisux**: "I don't think they will survive unless they ship it with some in-house RAM." The big thread was December 2025's, at 170 points. **Reddit refused every desk in this issue.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE $385 RASPBERRY PI IS ALSO A POSITIONING FAILURE

Raspberry Pi protected margin on its lowest-volume, highest-memory product and held another's price in the same post. That is allocation strategy as much as helpless pass-through, and the blog does not say which. More to the point, the 16GB Model 5 was never the right machine for a serious home lab even at $305: no error-correcting memory, four lanes of expansion, nowhere to put a graphics card. A second-hand desktop was the better buy before the rise, which is what *Tom's Hardware* argued in January. "Artificial intelligence took my single-board computer" is a satisfying frame for a product that had already been overtaken. **What would settle it:** the rollback, with a date on it.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Local models now answer the same question the same way. A change merged into llama.cpp on 8 November breaks ties by a fixed rule rather than by whichever parallel worker finished first, so repeated runs return byte-identical output. On one reproducer the drift measure went from 2.1721–2.1737 to **2.1724 three times running**. **Scope matters:** two back-ends only, and on most Apple machines it is marginally slower.[5]

SOURCES 1 Raspberry Pi's own blog post of 2 November 2026, "Price rises for some 16GB Raspberry Pi products", by Eben Upton, read at source, for every quoted sentence, the $80 and $40 figures, the $385 price, the held price of the 500+, the stated cause and the promise to roll back without a date. 4 The Hacker News thread of 8 November 2026, read at source through its public interface, handles and point counts as displayed, with both comments quoted in full; the December 2025 thread's metrics come from the same index. 6 Home Assistant's own release post for 2026.11, dated 4 November 2026, read at source, for the Matter camera support and its conditions, the two-way-audio preview and its secure-connection requirement, and the backward-incompatible naming change. **Its community forum returned 404 on both paths tried, so no forum sentiment appears for it.**

THE KIT · THE MACBOOK PRO

Apple's top 16-inch MacBook Pro now configures to $14,549

A 16-terabyte drive adds $7,000 and the jump to 128GB of memory adds $2,000. The same machine with 8TB cost $7,349 in March.

The most expensive laptop Apple will sell you now costs more than a small car, and the parts doing the damage are the two that store things rather than the one that thinks. Fill a 16-inch MacBook Pro to its limits on Apple's American store and the total reads **$14,549**. Eight months ago the same machine came to $7,349.[1]

This is the same story as the one on the previous page wearing a suit. Memory and storage chips are in short supply because the companies building artificial-intelligence data centres have bought the output, and every maker that needs them is passing the cost on — a single-board computer for a cupboard at one end of the market, a professional laptop at the other. The useful comparison is not the top line, which almost nobody buys, but what happened to the cheapest one.[2]

The configurator, read on 8 November: the top machine is a 16-inch with the OLED touchscreen, an **M5 Max** of 18 processing and 40 graphics cores, **128GB** of memory and a **16TB** drive. The drive alone adds **$7,000** — about $500 a terabyte, with no volume discount. Going from 48GB to 128GB adds **$2,000**, and only the 40-core part accepts 128GB. The non-touch 16-inch tops out at **$10,149** — also what this configuration cost in late June, with half the storage.[1]

The number that affects actual buyers sits lower on the same page. The entry 14-inch MacBook Pro is **$1,999**, up from **$1,699** after a June increase — a 17.7 per cent rise on the model most people buy, and the honest memory-shortage datapoint in a story otherwise told through a configuration that exists to be screenshotted.[1]

+98%

THE MAXED 16-INCH MACBOOK PRO, MARCH TO NOVEMBER, BY THIS DESK'S ARITHMETIC[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAYS ABOUT APPLE'S MEMORY BILL

The trade press reads the MacBook Pro's price as an input-cost story rather than a margin one. *Tom's Hardware* reports that Apple's manufacturing bill has risen by **$33 billion** in a few months on memory costs, threatening margins "through the holiday quarter and into 2027", with Samsung saying memory demand would far exceed supply. **This desk could read only that report's headline; its body was unreachable, so the $33 billion figure is printed as reported and this desk cannot say who estimated it.** No forum read is available: Reddit refused every desk in this issue.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY $14,549 IS A CONFIGURATOR, NOT A PRODUCT

Nobody buys a 16-terabyte internal drive, and Apple has charged a multiple for storage for fifteen years — long before the memory shortage existed. A Thunderbolt enclosure does the same job for a fraction, and the top line conflates a genuine input-cost shock with an unchanged policy on upgrades. Read the MacBook Pro story through the $1,699 to $1,999 move on the base 14-inch instead: that is a real price rise on a machine real people buy, and it is a fifth of the headline percentage. **What would settle it:** Apple's own gross-margin guidance for the holiday quarter.[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Anker's Soundcore Space 2 Pro, $200, scored 8.4. *Engadget*'s Billy Steele published on 6 November, praising "excellent voice clarity" and a measured **31 hours** against a claimed 30 with cancellation on, and marking down "average ANC performance" and extra audio features that "don't improve sound". **No ship date and no codec list are published, and the review gives two different microphone counts, so none is printed. The $200 is single-sourced: Soundcore's own product page returned 404.**[4]

Still on the shelf. Microsoft's Surface RTX Spark Dev Box, announced on 7 October at **$5,999.99** with 128GB of memory, is listed as shipping this month — though the page offers a pre-order button and no date. Nvidia's own DGX Spark launched at $3,999 and its 128GB version now sells near $7,000.[5]

SOURCES 1 *Engadget*, 8 November 2026, by Luke James, read at source, for the $14,549 total configuration on Apple's United States store, the component breakdown ($7,000 for 16TB, $2,000 for the memory step, $400 for the touchscreen), the restriction of 128GB to the 40-core part, the $10,149 non-touch ceiling, the March figure of $7,349 at 8TB and the end-June $10,149, the $5,399 M5 Max base and $3,399 entry 16-inch, and the base 14-inch moving from $1,699 to $1,999 after a June increase. 3 *Tom's Hardware*'s report on Apple's memory costs, cited by its published title and standfirst. **Announced 7 October, so only its shipping window is new.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE GENEVA WATCH AUCTION

Phillips closed Geneva XXIV on 8 November without publishing a total

So this desk counted every published lot result: CHF 91,922,250 across 211 lots, against the CHF 74.8m its May sale was called a record for.

The most closely watched watch auction in the world finished its second session in Geneva on Sunday afternoon and said nothing about how much it had made. Phillips' overview page for The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV reads "Concluded Nov 8, 2026". There is no total, and the results address such a house normally uses returns nothing.[1]

An auction total is the number the trade reads to judge whether the market is strong, and houses usually publish it within hours because it is good news. Its absence is worth a page. Since Phillips does publish every individual lot result, the total can be assembled by hand, and this desk did: all 225 lot entries downloaded, parsed, and every published sold price added. The figure is **CHF 91,922,250** across **211** lots with results.[2]

Two things must be said before that number is used. Sold prices on Phillips' own pages **include the buyer's premium**, which is how houses report totals, so it is comparable. But **ten lot numbers are missing** from the published results, and absence is not proof of withdrawal or failure. So **CHF 91,922,250 is a floor, not a total, and the sell-through cannot be stated.** One of the ten is lot 131, a Rolex 6264 "Paul Newman Lemon" Daytona estimated above CHF 1,000,000.[2]

On that floor the sale beat the **CHF 74.8m** of Phillips' May auction — the one trade titles called the highest-grossing watch sale in history — by about **23 per cent**. Session II alone made **CHF 43,215,750**. Its top lot was a titanium **F.P. Journe** Résonance made for the Tokyo boutique in 2007, estimated at CHF 400,000 to 800,000 and sold for **CHF 6,146,000** — 7.7 times its ceiling. Seventeen lots passed a million francs, and Journe took seven plus the top lot of both sessions.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE TRADE SAID BEFORE GENEVA XXIV

Ghulam Gows, writing for The Hour Markers on 15 October, previewed these sales as a test of provenance over condition and called the outcome in advance: the money would go to watches with "a named owner, an unusual configuration, or condition no one expected to find", and — flatly — **"Generic quality did not set records."** He framed the autumn as rewarding watches with "a real author, a real history, and a reason to exist beyond the catalog description". Writing in July, **Joey Sendz** of Trillionaire Daily described the buyer base behind it as "bigger, younger, more global" and "comfortable bidding on Rexhep Rexhepi and F.P. Journe", noting Phillips drew **1,815 registered bidders from 74 countries** in May.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY CHF 91.9M IS PARTLY AN ESTIMATING ERROR

A record built on lots that sold at seven times their high estimate is a record about the estimates. Lot 161 made 7.7 times its ceiling; a Journe Vagabondage III made 7.2; a Voutilainen 3.8; a Dufour Simplicity 2.8. A house whose own specialists misprice a maker by a factor of seven is not measuring a market. The genuinely blue-chip lots, by contrast, landed inside or barely above their ranges — the steel Patek 1436 at CHF 6,267,000 on a CHF 2m–4m estimate, the Cartier Portico at CHF 4,815,000 on CHF 1.8m–3.6m. And on the bulls' own evidence the breadth is missing: Trillionaire Daily concedes that "trophy lots cleared at records while the broad market for standard high-grade pieces sat flat". **What would settle it:** Phillips publishing the total and the sell-through.[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A roomful heard the $3,799 flagship, and still nobody has measured it. Audio-Technica's **ATH-AWX7000** went on sale on 6 November and met Japanese listeners for the first time at the **42nd Autumn Headphone Festival** in Tokyo on the 7th — housings in Kiso hinoki finished in Echizen urushi lacquer, a 58mm driver, 48 ohms, about 353 grams. **No published measurement exists, four issues after this desk first asked.**[4]

SOURCES 1 Phillips' own overview page for The Geneva Watch Auction: XXIV, read at source, for the sessions of 7 and 8 November 2026 at the Hotel President Wilson, the lot ranges 1–107 and 108–221, the association with Bacs & Russo and the "Concluded Nov 8, 2026" status with no total. **Its results address returned 404.** 2 Phillips' own browse page for the sale, downloaded in full and parsed by this desk, for all 211 published lot results and every estimate and sold price quoted here, including Session I at CHF 48,706,500 over 106 lots and Session II at CHF 43,215,750 over 105. **Sold prices on that page include the buyer's premium. Ten lot numbers carry no published result and are listed in the text; the CHF 91,922,250 is therefore a floor and no sell-through is claimed. The $3,799 is that report's figure, not the maker's: Audio-Technica's United States site returned 403 and the Japanese store price did not render. Brise Audio's own domain does not resolve for this desk.**

SCREEN & SOUND · GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

Godzilla Minus Zero opened to $31.6m and took the American No. 1

GKIDS set a company record, nearly tripling the $11.4m opening of Godzilla Minus One. Japan's own weekend figure has still not been published.

A **Japanese film in Japanese took the top of the American box office this weekend, earning $31,610,000 from 3,254 cinemas.** Its distributor, GKIDS, has never had a bigger opening; its previous best, *The Boy and the Heron*, took $13m in 2023. Audiences graded it A, critics 90 per cent on 172 reviews.[1]

Two records sit inside that figure and both are about language rather than monsters. It is the **second-biggest opening ever for a live-action film not in English** in America, behind only *The Passion of the Christ*'s $83m in 2004, and only the **fourth** non-English film to top the weekend chart. Its predecessor, *Godzilla Minus One*, opened to $11.4m in December 2023 and finished at $57.1m — a five-fold multiplier built over weeks.[2]

The daily shape is where the argument lives. Wednesday previews took **$6.7m**, Friday **$14.6m**, Saturday **$9.45m**, Sunday **$7.56m**. Worldwide it is at **$63m**, with **$31.39m** from abroad. It opened in Japan on **3 November**, Godzilla Day. Second place went to *The Cat in the Hat*, on **$20.5m** from 4,003 sites.[1]

And here is the hole in the record. **Japan's opening-weekend figure does not exist at source.** Kogyo Tsushin publishes on a Monday and its newest ranking covers 30 October to 1 November. The two numbers circulating for the Japanese cumulative do not describe the same thing: one tracker gives **$8.7m as of 6 November**, a trade report **¥2.7bn**, about $17m, since the Tuesday. **This desk could not read the second at source and prints neither as settled.**[3]

$31.6m

GKIDS' LARGEST OPENING WEEKEND, FROM 3,254 CINEMAS AT A $9,714 AVERAGE[1]

THE CHATTER · HOW AUDIENCES GRADED GODZILLA MINUS ZERO

The audience read on *Godzilla Minus Zero* is unusually clean, because two independent instruments agree. Exit polling gave it a **CinemaScore of A**. On Rotten Tomatoes, read this morning, it stands at **90 per cent from 172 critic reviews** and **96 per cent from more than 2,500 verified audience ratings**; the consensus credits director **Takashi Yamazaki** with keeping very large-scale action anchored in human interest. **One correction worth making: a figure circulating in search summaries has critics at 64 per cent. Against Rotten Tomatoes itself that is simply wrong.** Reddit refused every desk in this issue, so no forum sentiment appears.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY GODZILLA MINUS ZERO'S OPENING MAY BE ITS CEILING

The opening is not the story; the multiplier is, and this one is shaped wrongly for a long run. *Minus One* earned its $57.1m by starting small and holding for weeks. *Minus Zero* has front-loaded a franchise-record weekend into $6.7m of previews and a $14.6m Friday, then **fell 35 per cent from Friday to Saturday** — the curve of a fanbase arriving at once, not of a film finding an audience. On those dailies a conventional multiplier lands it near its predecessor's lifetime rather than far beyond it. Add that every weekend figure here is a studio estimate rather than an actual, and that the Japanese cumulative is reported two ways. **What would settle it:** the second American weekend, and Japan's first full one.[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

My Chemical Romance reached No. 1 twenty years late. *The Black Parade* is reported to have gone from No. 139 to the top of the Billboard 200 dated 7 November on 78,000 units, 68,000 of them pure sales — said to be the largest jump to No. 1 in the chart's history. The driver is a 20th-anniversary reissue of **23 October** with six bonus tracks and multiple vinyl variants. **Billboard is paywalled to this desk and the chart was read on a reposting site, so every figure here is printed as reported, not verified.**[6]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend chart for the 45th weekend of 2026 and The Numbers' title page, both read at source, for the $31,610,000 opening, the 3,254 cinemas and $9,714 average, the Wednesday-to-Sunday dailies, the $63m worldwide and $31.39m international, the release dates by territory and *The Cat in the Hat*'s $20.5m from 4,003 sites. 3 The Numbers' territory table, read at source, for Japan at $8.7m as of 6 November 2026. **The ¥2.7bn figure is attributed to a trade report this desk could not read: every Penske-owned title redirects to a paywall returning 402. 5 The multiplier argument is this desk's, from the dailies in note 1. 6 The Billboard 200 dated 7 November 2026 and the reissue's contents and release date. billboard.com returned 402 and npr.org 503, so the chart positions and unit figures were read on a chart-reposting blog and the record claims come from search summaries of Billboard and NPR rather than from either. The reissue contents and 23 October date are from NME, read at source. Sources also disagree on the Toby Keith gap, one giving near sixteen years.**

THE FAMILY DESK · THE WHO ACTIVITY REPORT

A quarter of adolescents told the WHO of no active day in a week

A pooled analysis of 389 surveys and 3.2 million 11-to-17-year-olds, published 4 November, finds the figure has not moved since 2010.

The World Health Organization reported on 4 November that a quarter of the world's adolescents — about 240 million of them — could not name a single day in the previous week on which they had been physically active for an hour. The finding pools **389 population surveys** across **140 countries**, covering more than **3.2 million** young people aged 11 to 17, and runs from 2010 to 2025.[1]

The number that should give a parent pause is not the quarter. It is the flatness. Across fifteen years — the years in which the smartphone arrived, saturated and became the thing every adult blames — this measure has barely moved. If devices had collapsed how much children move, this is the series in which it would show, and it does not. Whatever is happening is older and slower than the thing in her hand.[1]

The detail. The mean is **2.7 active days a week**; **14 per cent** manage all seven. The gap by sex is wide and consistent: **28 per cent of girls report zero active days against 22 per cent of boys**, and **11 per cent of girls are active daily against 17 per cent of boys**. Director-General **Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus**'s line is that "girls are being left furthest behind". Country figures range from about 4 per cent to over 40; roughly 40 per cent report zero days in Namibia, Nepal and the Philippines, while over 30 per cent are active daily in Bangladesh and Serbia. **No country is on track** for the 2030 target.[1]

Two honest limits before anyone acts on it. **This desk could not obtain a single confidence interval** — the organisation's news item and publication page carry none, the journal refused our requests, and the report itself sat behind a refusal. Nor could we find any Singapore figure in it, so none is printed. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

2.7

MEAN ACTIVE DAYS A WEEK AMONG 11-TO-17-YEAR-OLDS, WORLDWIDE[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE PARENTS ARE READING THIS MONTH

For a Singapore family the activity question lands in a very particular fortnight. A child born in July 2014 sat this year's Primary School Leaving Examination — the marking exercise ran **12 to 14 October** — and the results come out, tentatively, on **24 and 25 November**. She is in the gap. **KiasuParents**, writing with Fei Yue Community Services on 28 September, frames October to December as exactly the window in which screen habits set, and its advice inverts the usual order: plan the week around sleep, meals, exercise and family time **first**, and fit recreational screen time into what is left, with the child's input. **Reddit and the Singapore parenting forums all refused this desk, so no parent is quoted here; this is a named publication's editorial voice, not a community read.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY "NO ACTIVE DAYS" IS A SURVEY ANSWER, NOT A MEASUREMENT

Everything here rests on one self-reported question asked across 389 differently-translated instruments: on how many of the past seven days were you active for at least sixty minutes? A child who walks to school, climbs stairs and messes about at recess can answer zero and be telling the truth — the question asks about structured hour-long bouts, not about her life. **Ulf Ekelund**'s standing critique of this literature is that its conclusions rest on self-report, and that device-measured dose-response curves are **steeper and appear at lower activity levels** than self-report implies; a study of **34,183** UK Biobank participants found self-reported and device-measured activity implied different minimum effective doses. Pooling across 140 countries also mixes question wording, translation and recall windows. **What would settle it:** accelerometry at this scale, which nobody has.[4]

SOURCES 1 The World Health Organization's own news item of 4 November 2026 and its publication page, both read at source, for the one-in-four and 240 million figures, the 389 surveys, 140 countries and 3.2 million participants, the 2010–2025 window, the 2.7-day mean, the 14 per cent active daily, the sex split, the country range and the 2030 target; the Director-General is quoted from the news item. The named country figures and the author string for the accompanying journal paper come from a trade report of 7 November 2026, read at source. **That article contains no parent quotations; its sample scripts are the author's.** 4 Ekelund, Tarp, Sanchez-Lastra and Dalene, "Physical activity, sedentary time and health", *Danish Medical Journal* 2024;71, and Sanchez-Lastra et al., *Journal of Sport and Health Science*, online 24 December 2025, both read at source through a bibliographic interface, for the self-report critique and the UK Biobank comparison. **All of this page is general guidance, not medical advice.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE SCHOOL-START TRIAL

A French trial moved school an hour later and bought 22.8 minutes of sleep

The mean age was 12.8. Bedtimes did not drift later to swallow the gain — the shift was 8.9 minutes earlier, and not significant.

A randomised trial in a French boarding school moved four classes from an eight o'clock start to nine and measured what happened to their sleep over six months: they gained 22.8 minutes a night. The usual objection to later school starts is that teenagers simply stay up later and the gain evaporates. In this trial they did not.[1]

That matters here because of who was in it. The participants were aged **11.7 to 14.2, mean 12.8** — a band that actually contains a twelve-year-old, which is rarer in this literature than it should be. Most school-start research is done on fifteen- to eighteen-year-olds and then applied downwards. This one was not.[1]

The numbers, with their intervals. Total sleep time by wrist actigraphy rose **22.8 minutes** (95% CI 7.6 to 37.9, d=0.93, p=0.007), and the absolute gap against controls at six months was **26 minutes** (10 to 43). Daytime sleepiness fell **2.0 points** (−3.7 to −0.2). Inhibitory control improved by **67.9 milliseconds** (−108.3 to −27.4). And the key null: **bedtime moved 8.9 minutes earlier** (−24.7 to +7.0, p=0.520) and sleep onset 6.0 minutes earlier (p=0.806) — neither significant, both in the wrong direction for the drift hypothesis. Evening types gained most, **28.5 minutes**; morning types gained nothing measurable.[1]

The authors' own closing caveat is worth carrying: **even in the delayed group, sleep remained short.** A later start is not a cure; it bought twenty-three minutes. And if your twelve-year-old is a lark rather than an owl, this trial predicts nothing for her. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[1]

−8.9 min

THE BEDTIME SHIFT — EARLIER, NOT LATER, AND NOT STATISTICALLY SIGNIFICANT[1]

THE CHATTER · THE EVIDENCE PARENTS WILL WEIGH AGAINST 22.8 MINUTES

A parent told that moving the school day bought a French twelve-year-old **22.8 minutes** of sleep will immediately ask what the screen in her room is costing, and the best current summary of that deflates both sides. A JAMA *Pediatrics* umbrella review published on **28 September** pooled **23 meta-analyses and 2,817,252 children** across 64 countries. Screen use and internalising problems: **r=0.10** (95% CI 0.07 to 0.13). Externalising: 0.11. Academic achievement: −0.15. And a row of nulls — executive function 0.01, reading −0.02, science −0.03. **Dr Tatiana Íñiguez Berrozpe** of Zaragoza puts the size in words: it is about **one per cent of the difference between groups**, and "it in no way supports the mantra that screens are the main cause of adolescent emotional distress". **Reddit and the Singapore parenting forums refused this desk, so no parent is quoted on either study.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE 22.8 MINUTES HAS A WIDER INTERVAL THAN PRINTED

The trial randomised four classes and then analysed about fifty individuals as though they were independent — and the authors say so themselves. Their intraclass correlation estimates came out unstable, negative and widely bounded, so clustering was not modelled at all. With four clusters treated as fifty people, **those confidence intervals are almost certainly too narrow**, and the true interval on 22.8 minutes is wider than the one above. Add: actigraphy compliance was worse among boys and in the control arm; nobody can be blinded to a school start time, so the self-reported sleepiness is open to expectancy; the chronotype finding is exploratory and underpowered; no mental-health or academic outcomes were measured at all; and a French boarding school is not a Singapore day school with a commute. **What would settle it:** a cluster-randomised replication with enough clusters to model.[1]

SOURCES 1 *Scientific Reports* 2026;16:22215, online 15 May 2026, open access and read in full at source, for the design, the four classes randomised by school administrators, the 86 students allocated and the 50 analysed by actigraphy and 73 by questionnaire, the age band and mean, the six-month difference-in-differences, every effect size and confidence interval quoted, the non-significant bedtime and sleep-onset shifts, the chronotype result and its underpowering, the funding by the French national education research council and the national research agency, the authors' declaration of no competing interests, and every limitation set out in the Sceptic including the unstable intraclass correlations and the decision not to model clustering. **Note for the reader: one of that paper's authors is the journal's editor-in-chief. Its funding statement and formal conflict disclosures were behind a subscription and could not be read, and the record does not say how age moderated the associations — so it cannot be cited as a finding about twelve-year-olds specifically, and is not. All of this page is general guidance, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · THE WAR PREMIUM

A falling Brent price, not growth fear, drove the week's bond rally

The US ten-year yield fell 5bp on the week to 4.86 per cent while its real yield rose 1bp. The implied breakeven did all the work, collapsing from 2.29 to 2.23.

Brent crude fell about 12.5 per cent in the week to Friday 6 November, as diplomacy between Washington and Tehran mediated by Qatar took the war premium out of a barrel without adding a single barrel to supply. That, and not any fear about growth, is what moved the United States bond market: it spent the week marking down how much inflation it expects.[1]

A government bond yield splits into two parts: the real return a lender demands, and the inflation they expect to be compensated for. The United States Treasury publishes both curves daily, so the split can be read rather than modelled. Over the week the **nominal** ten-year fell from 4.91 to **4.86 per cent** while the **real** ten-year rose from 2.62 to **2.63**. The compensation between them went from **2.29 to 2.23**. The entire rally was those 6 basis points.[2]

The policy leg is the two-year. It fell to **4.46 per cent** on Thursday's rout and came back to **4.51** on Friday, after the Bureau of Labor Statistics reported **165,000** October payrolls, unemployment at **4.1 per cent**, earnings up **0.4 per cent**, and revisions adding **84,000** jobs to August and September. A labour market that refuses to crack keeps a hawkish path alive while the inflation impulse fades. Name the regime: **a deflating supply-shock scare with a hawkish central bank attached** — not a growth scare, and not an inflation scare either.[3]

Diversification worked this week, and the reason should worry anyone relying on it. Equities fell hard — the Nasdaq Composite **5.5 per cent** on Thursday, the S&P 500 **4.4** — and bonds rallied, so a mixed portfolio was cushioned. But the cushion came from **breakevens, not real yields**: it was paid for by the oil price, not by the bond market's view of growth. If Hormuz re-tightens, or OPEC+ sets a hard 2027 framework at its full meeting on **29 November**, breakevens reverse and bonds stop hedging equities in the same week the equity problem worsens.[1]

−6bp

THE IMPLIED TEN-YEAR BREAKEVEN, 2.29 TO 2.23 PER CENT, 2 TO 6 NOVEMBER[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BITCOIN

Global equities took the week's damage and got the oil relief second-hand; a lower breakeven helps them only if the hawkish path dies, and Friday's payrolls said it has not. **Global bonds** did their job on the wrong leg — borrowed from oil, not earned from growth. **Gold** rose about 4 per cent with real yields up a basis point, so the textbook channel was off and the move was haven bid and a softer dollar; it is up only 1.7 per cent over twelve months, which makes it a hedging flow, not a trend. **Bitcoin** fell 2.6 per cent and then flat-lined all weekend in a $565 band on a quarter of Friday's volume. **In a week when the haven trade paid four per cent, bitcoin lost two and a half.** Whatever it is for, it is not insurance. **Explanation, not advice.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE BREAKEVEN READING OF THE WEEK MAY BE WRONG

The breakeven used here is this desk's own subtraction, not a published series. Taking the par nominal curve minus the par real curve is a proxy; the published inflation-swap and TIPS breakevens can differ by several basis points, and six is a small number to hang a thesis on. A one-basis-point rise in a real yield is also inside the noise of daily curve fitting. The alternative reading is simpler: Thursday was an equity-driven flight to quality that dragged nominals down and had largely unwound by Friday's bounce, and the oil move is a separate story that happens to rhyme. **What would settle it:** Tuesday's October inflation print, which will move breakevens directly.[2]

SOURCES 1 Brent's close of $98.32 on 6 November 2026 and the weekly move, read at source on a market data service; the 2 November diplomacy and the fall from $108.64, OPEC+ leaving December targets unchanged on 1 November, the delayed capacity review, the 29 November meeting and the remaining cuts, from a trade report of 2 November read at source. **opec.org returned 402 to this desk, so no figure here rests on the organisation's own text, and the trade outlet is a small one.** 2 The United States Treasury's own daily par yield and daily real yield curve files for November 2026, read at source, for every nominal and real figure quoted, measured 2 November to 6 November. **The breakeven is this desk's arithmetic from those two curves and is a proxy for, not a reading of, the published breakeven.** 3 The Bureau of Labor Statistics' Employment Situation release of Friday 6 November 2026, read at source, for payrolls, the unemployment rate, average hourly earnings and the August and September revisions; and its own release schedule, read at source, for the 10 November inflation date. **Reported exchange-traded-fund outflows are omitted: two sources gave two different figures and neither was primary.** 5 The Straits Times Index close of 5,179.17 on 6 November 2026, read at source. **None of this page is investment advice.**

THE INVITATION · ICE CLIMBING

Petzl and C.A.M.P. both recalled ice axes as the climbing season opened

Petzl recalled 5,360 Nomic and Ergonomic axes in March after 26 shafts broke; C.A.M.P. recalled 2,230 more on 5 November. Nobody was hurt in either.

Ice climbing is the business of going up a frozen waterfall on two short picked axes and a set of steel spikes strapped to your boots, and its northern season opens this month. It opens awkwardly: in nine months the two best-known makers of those axes have each recalled a flagship model for a failure that would drop a climber off the route.[1]

The appeal is easy to state and hard to believe until you have done it. A waterfall freezes; a climber swings a tool into it until the pick holds, kicks a front point in, and moves up on four small points of contact in a material that was liquid last month and will be again. The whole thing exists for about three months a year, in places cold enough, and then it drains away.[2]

The grades tell you the ladder's shape. **WI** is water ice: WI1 is low-angle and needs no axes; **WI3** is sustained seventy degrees and the point it becomes technical climbing; **WI5** a full pitch of near-vertical with few rests; **WI7** thin, badly bonded ice on overhanging columns, which Will Gadd calls "semi-mythical". **And the grade with the most accidents is WI2**, the easy one, where people stop being careful. Above the scale sits one wall: Helmcken Falls, where routes graded **WI10 to WI13** have been bolted since 2010 and the ceiling has not moved since 2020.[2]

How big is this world? **Nobody knows, and that is the honest answer.** The American outdoor industry does not count ice climbers separately, bundling them into "traditional, ice and mountaineering climbing" — about 2.9 million people in 2025. The one hard piece of infrastructure is the **Ouray Ice Park**: over **150 named routes** across nearly two miles of gorge, free, public, farmed by a nonprofit that sprays water down the walls. The best proxy for demand is a sold-out sign: at the Bozeman Ice Festival on 9–13 December, almost every one of some twenty-five clinics has gone, including the introductory ones at $180.[3]

The sport's single most important venue opened two days before its own festival in 2026.

99 ± 4

DAYS IN A MOUNT WASHINGTON VALLEY ICE SEASON, MEASURED ACROSS TWENTY YEARS[4]

THE CHATTER · WHERE ICE CLIMBERS ACTUALLY ARGUE

The centre of gravity is **Mountain Project's Ice Climbing forum**, fifty-two pages deep, and its culture is metallurgical rather than ethical: steel hardness, hoop tension, the galling of stainless fasteners. The defining thread is **"Petzl Ice Tool Failures" — 589 replies over thirty pages**, opened by **Karl Henize** on 22 January 2024 with the sentence "I am trying to compile information on current generation Petzl tools that have broken unexpectedly" and the observation that no recall existed. **The recall arrived two years later.** The regional sites it replaced are dead: New England Ice's newest conditions report is from November 2019. **Reddit refused every desk in this issue, and UKClimbing's forums returned a payment wall, so no British voices appear in this descent.**[5]

DOWN THE NEXT TWO PAGES

The gear (p16) — what a tool, a crampon, a boot and a screw actually cost in November 2026, what the forums say breaks, and why almost none of the good stuff is in stock.

The custom tier, the economics and the climate argument (p17) — the Russian workshop that will not take your order, the honest price of being equipped at three levels, and a peer-reviewed answer to whether the season is shortening.

SOURCES 1 The United States Consumer Product Safety Commission's recall notices, both read at source: recall 26-347 of 26 March 2026 for the Petzl Nomic and Ergonomic, following Petzl's own safety alert of 23 February, covering about 4,200 units in the United States and 1,160 in Canada on 26 reports of shafts breaking at the handle with no injuries; and recall 27-070 of 5 November 2026 for C.A.M.P.'s X-Dream and X-All Mountain axes, about 2,230 units, for a screw that can loosen until the handle or pick detaches, also with no injuries. 2 The Wikipedia articles on ice climbing and on climbing grades, read at source, for the water-ice, alpine-ice and mixed disciplines, the American Alpine Club grade descriptors and the commentary attributed there to Will Gadd's *Ice & Mixed Climbing: Modern Technique*, including the WI2 accident observation and the "semi-mythical" WI7, and for the Helmcken Falls routes and dates. 4 Voorhis, McDowell, Burakowski and Luneau, "The implications of warmer winters for ice climbing", *Frontiers in Human Dynamics* 5:1097414 (2023), read in full at source; see p17. 5 Mountain Project's Ice Climbing forum and the named thread, read at source on 8 November 2026, reply counts and handles as displayed; NEice's own site, read at source, for the date of its newest conditions report.

THE DEEP END · THE TOOLS, BOOTS AND SCREWS

Petzl, Black Diamond and Grivel have little of the good gear in stock

A Petzl Nomic is $379.95 and a Black Diamond Hydra $399.95. On the day the season opened, both were unavailable at the specialist that listed them.

Ice climbing's kit comes down to four purchases — the two axes, the crampons, the boots and the screws — and this page is about what each of them costs in November 2026 and what owners say breaks. The short version is that the category has stopped advancing and started going out of stock.[1]

Start with the axes, the thing a beginner over-buys. The consensus workhorse is **Black Diamond's Hydra at $399.95**, 610 grams, rated 4.8 from 29 reviews on the maker's own page, with a standing complaint that the spike and adze cost extra. The default endgame is a pair of **Petzl Nomics at $379.95 each** — beloved, and now carrying a recall on its 2017–2022 production. Above sit **DMM's Cortex at CA$695.95** and Grivel's rebranded **Nexus Machine at a reported $759 a tool**, about 1.8 times its own Dark Machine at $419.99.[1]

The specialist trap is instructive. Alpinist gave the Dark Machine **3.5 stars** and the verdict "a tool for the focused specialist", because on low-angle ice "the pommel contacts the ice first and spits the pick out". On Mountain Project, **ryan Smith** sold his after a few days: "The percent of first swing good sticks that i get with nomics is way higher then with dark machines." Against which **NateC**: "I feel like I fatigue less quickly with it than with the heavier Nomic." **The argument is unresolved.**[2]

Boots are the hardest decision and the least spec-driven. **La Sportiva's G-Summit** is $929 with a dial closure; **Scarpa's Phantom Tech HD** is CA$999, 800 grams a half-pair. But the forum argues about fit, not materials. **NateC** on the Phantom Tech had to "lace it super tight" and still "barely had a heel lock", with feet "always cold". **Bruno Schull** puts the stake plainly: "If your toes go numb, not only is climbing uncomfortable, it's far less precise and secure." The drift is to stiff single boots; in a whole comparison thread, nobody chose a double.[2]

CA$239.95

A PAIR OF PETZL DART FOREFOOT SECTIONS — A SPARE PART DEARER THAN MANY CRAMPONS[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ICE CLIMBERS SAY ABOUT SCREWS AND PICKS

Two live verdicts, both from Mountain Project and both blunt. On **Edelrid's Raya Lite** screw, pitched as the lightest made: **Torstein Derauf** did the arithmetic in November 2025 — the blue is **two grams** lighter than a rival, the red not lighter at all — and called it "mildly deceitful marketing". Having used them, **Kevin Mcbride** wrote in October 2026: it places "marginally better than an old BD steel screw", the hanger hole is too small to rack, and "My advice to anyone looking at buying these is simple; Don't." On **aluminium-bodied screws**, which crack: **Grant Watson**, "just one more reason to avoid aluminum screws"; **Keys Layn**, "Add it to the giant pile of reasons not use aluminum screws." **Reddit refused this desk, so every voice here is from one named forum.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY EXPENSIVE PICKS MAY BE ICE CLIMBING'S MONEY PIT

The pick is a consumable that people buy like an heirloom. Nick Sweeney: "I haven't found an aftermarket pick for any tool that outperforms the Petzl Pur'ice." **Sam Serra**: "How sharp a pick is probably matters more than slight changes in geometry." And the boutique ones break — Nick snapped a Howey on pure WI4 and bent a Beartooth on fat WI3, and **Doug Hutchinson** on the revered Krukonogi pure-ice pick: "they are really delicate and only for pure ice without a rock around for miles." **Bug Boy** says the quiet part: "hard to justify the price for a disposable piece of gear." Against it, **NateC**: "the higher quality picks... last at least twice as long." **What would settle it:** a wear test nobody has run.[2]

SOURCES 1 Prices read at source on 8 November 2026 at each maker's or retailer's own page: Black Diamond's own site for the Hydra's $399.95, 610g, review score and the separately-sold spike and adze, and for the redesigned Viper at $329.95; a Canadian specialist's catalogue for the Nomic at $379.95, the Cortex at CA$695.95 and the Dart forefoot sections at CA$239.95; Alpinist for the Dark Machine's $419.99 list; La Sportiva's $929 G-Summit via retailer listings and Scarpa's own Canadian page for the Phantom Tech HD at CA$999 with its weight and construction. 3 Stock states read at source at each named retailer on 8 November 2026. **REI, Backcountry, Oliunid, Snowleader, Bananafingers and La Sportiva's own site all refused this desk, and Petzl's product pages return 404 to it, so Petzl figures rest on retailer listings at matching prices rather than on the maker's own page.**

THE DEEP END · THE PRICE AND THE SEASON

A complete ice-climbing outfit tops out near $5,000, Krukonogi included

A peer-reviewed study puts one valley's season at 99 days now and 30 by 2100 on high emissions. Ouray opened two days before its own festival in 2026.

Ice climbing costs less to equip than almost any sport with this much gear talk, and this page is about the numbers at three levels and about whether there will be anything left to climb. A complete buy-once outfit is roughly **$2,900 to $3,300**, and the ceiling of the sport's gear economy is about **$5,000**.[1]

Build it from the sourced parts. **The real entry point** — two Hydras at $799.90, Stinger crampons at $269.95, a Phantom Tech HD at roughly $720, helmet and harness about $305, six Express screws from $479.70 and a treated half rope about $210 — lands at **$2,785 to $2,905** before clothing. **The endgame** swaps in two Nomics at $759.90, a $929 G-Summit and six Ultralight screws at $659.70, reaching **$4,200 to $4,800 clothed**. Set all of it against the governing body's reconfirmation in September that Russian athletes stay suspended for the 2026–27 season — while the most coveted picks in the sport are made in Russia.[3][1]

The custom tier is real, tiny and mostly shut. **Krukonogi**, the Russian workshop whose picks the forum covets, lists the Anchar 7 at **$1,050 a tool** plus €200–300 shipping, and its own page says **"we are not accepting orders"**. **EliteClimb's** Morphos run about $1,600 a pair; **Forecast Equipment** lists all four of its tools out of stock. The universal craft is free: every serious climber files their own picks.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHETHER THE ICE SEASON IS STILL REAL

The climbers' answer is angrier and more local than the data. In January 2026 the **Ouray Ice Park** could not open: **B F**, 7 January, "All the Ice Clinics are cancelled for the All In Ice Fest." Then it turned — **Gregory Bunting**, 20 January: "The Ouray Ice Park officially opens for the season Tomorrow", **two days before its own festival**. The flat verdicts: **Joseph W. Dutton**, "Global warming has wrecked this sport". And the complication nobody mentions: **Double J** called 2025–26 "worst season for as long as I can remember" in Utah while **Nick Huhn** reported "Here in the Midwest it has been great." The season did not shrink so much as move.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT ICE CLIMBING'S GEAR IS ACTUALLY SELLING

Ice climbing's hype is not in the climbing. It is in the gear's claim to progress. A sport whose protection is a screw, whose technique is unchanged since the 1970s and whose grading ceiling has not moved since 2020 shipped, in twelve months: two safety recalls on flagship tools, a "lightest" screw two grams lighter than a rival, a $759 axe, and a boutique pick-maker closing its order book. The Nomic has barely changed in a decade and its most-discussed property is whether the handle breaks. **The honest pitch is not that the gear is advancing: it is close to finished, the good stuff is often unbuyable, and what you buy is three months a year of a sensation nothing else reproduces.**[5]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S HOBBY

Netsuke & miniature carving — boxwood, antler and a legal minefield, carved at thumbnail scale.

Historical European martial arts (HEMA) — reading a 1410 manuscript, then hitting someone with a steel feder.

Change ringing (English tower bells) — a permutation algorithm you perform with a rope and a ton of bronze.

SOURCES 1 Every component price is read at source and listed on p16; **the three totals are this desk's arithmetic from those components, and no published figure for the cost of an ice-climbing outfit exists anywhere this desk could find.** The Scarpa figure is converted from its Canadian and European list prices, since no United States price was readable. The sharpening-guide dead links are reported in a Mountain Project thread read at source. 4 Mountain Project threads read at source on 8 November 2026, handles and dates as displayed. 5 This desk's argument, from the recalls and products described here and on p15 and p16. The authors warn that adaptation — climbing thinner ice earlier, and more mixed ground — can mask the change, which is exactly what the forum describes.

FITNESS · ISOMETRIC HANDGRIP

A Brazilian trial found squeezing a handgrip beat squeezing with the legs

Four weeks of handgrip holds cut awake diastolic pressure by about 4.5 mmHg against controls; the identical protocol done with the legs moved nothing at all.

A randomised trial in Porto Alegre, published on 1 November, found that gripping something hard for two minutes at a time, three times a week, lowered the daytime blood pressure of adults already medicated for it. The same exercise with the far larger muscles of the thigh did nothing measurable — which contradicts the assumption the method rests on.[1]

The assumption matters because it is the one sold in longevity circles. Isometric exercise — holding a muscle under tension without moving — is the fashionable blood-pressure intervention, and the recommended versions are wall sits and leg holds, on the reasoning that more muscle mass means a bigger effect. This trial tested that directly, at matched intensity, and the hand won. The authors conclude the response "is not determined solely by the amount of muscle mass recruited".[1]

The detail. Sixty-seven adults with controlled hypertension, all medicated, were randomised to control (22), handgrip (22) or knee extension (23) and did **twelve supervised sessions over four weeks**: four sets of two-minute one-sided holds at **30 per cent of maximum voluntary contraction**, alternating sides. Adjusted awake systolic came out at **121.8 mmHg** for handgrip against **124.2** for control (p=0.017), awake diastolic **76.3** against **80.8** (p=0.009). Knee extension against control: not significant. Twenty-four-hour and sleeping pressures: not significant.[1]

Set against this book's other blood-pressure number the pair is almost too neat: the cuff training covered two issues ago **raised** systolic pressure by 5.30 mmHg, where the pooled handgrip estimate **lowers** it by 5.38. Both are surrogate endpoints; there is no mortality outcome in this literature. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

THE CHATTER · THE DOSE THE FIELD PRESCRIBES FOR HANDGRIP TRAINING

The protocol this trial used is not an invention; it is the one the field's own meta-analysis prescribes. A systematic review of **31 studies and 905 participants** published in April set the dose at four sets of two-minute one-sided contractions at or above 30 per cent of maximum, up to three times a week, **for at least eight weeks**, and pooled the effect at **−5.38 mmHg systolic** (95% CI −6.91 to −3.85) and **−2.71 diastolic** (−3.75 to −1.66). The new trial ran that recommendation at exactly 30 per cent and exactly three times a week — and for **half the prescribed duration. This desk could reach no forum, podcast transcript or community thread: Reddit refused every desk in this issue, so no first-hand sentiment is reported.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE HANDGRIP RESULT MAY BE BASELINE IMBALANCE

The handgrip trial has no baseline ambulatory measurement, and the authors say so first among their limitations. Pressure over 24 hours was recorded once, after the intervention. A 2.4 mmHg gap between three small, unblinded groups that **already differed at baseline in height, weight and physical activity** is as consistent with imbalance as with four weeks of gripping. It also ran at half the evidence-based duration. And the effect has deflated for fifteen years as trials improved: early pooled estimates ran near 13 mmHg, the 2026 meta-analysis puts it at 5.38, with heterogeneity of 86 per cent — so high the pooled figure is barely a summary. **What would settle it:** an eight-week trial with baseline monitoring.[2]

SOURCES 1 Oliveira PC, Waclawovsky G, Lehnen AM, "Four weeks of isometric handgrip training results in lower awake ambulatory blood pressure compared with control: a randomized clinical trial", *Clinical Physiology and Functional Imaging* 2026;46(6):e70102, online 1 November 2026, registered as NCT07147595 and funded by CAPES; full text read at source, for the three-arm design and arm sizes, the twelve-session protocol and its intensity, the adjusted awake means and their p-values, the null results for knee extension and for 24-hour and sleeping pressure, the authors' quoted conclusion and every limitation given in the Sceptic. **The comparison with the cuff-restriction figure is this desk's, between two separately sourced estimates.** 3 Deboutte J, Delecluse C, Thomis M, Van Roie E, *Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports* 2026;36(11):e70392, online 1 November 2026, registered as NCT06449716, open access and read at source, for the sample and attrition, the twelve-week protocol, the unmet primary hypothesis with its interval and p-value, the null functional outcomes and the one-repetition-maximum divergence, and for the absence of a non-exercising control. **All of this page is general guidance, not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · SINGAPORE AIRLINES

Singapore Airlines cut business class six inches wide on the A350

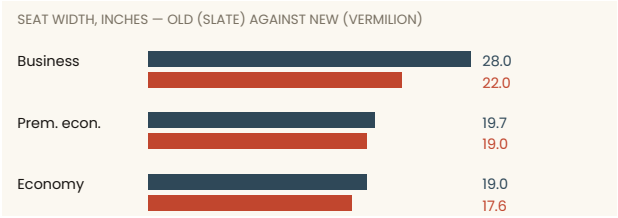
The 2027 seat unveiled on 6 November is 22 inches across, against 28 on the 2013 one. Reviewers spent the weekend arguing about the yellow instead.

Singapore Airlines showed its next generation of cabins at Marina Bay Sands on 6 November, and the loudest reaction was to the colour scheme. The new business-class seat is mineral grey with bright yellow accents — "Cool Yellow", named by the design studio — and the airline's most attentive reviewers did not care for it. The seats themselves now slip to **the second half of 2027.**[1]

The dimensions are the story the colours buried. The new business seat is **22 inches wide on the A350 against 28 inches on the seat it replaces** — a six-inch cut — and 24 inches on the 777-9, where Qantas gives 25 on its A350. The cabins behind it go the same way. **Premium economy rises to 36 seats** from 28 and gains two inches of pitch, to 40, but narrows from 19.7 to **19.0 inches**. **Economy rises to 204 seats** from 184, at a pitch of **31 to 32 inches** — so some rows fall below today's 32 — and narrows from 19.0 to **17.6 inches**. More seats, more screen, less shoulder.[2]

Both new cabins are **777-9 exclusive**; the A350s keep their seats with a refresh. Singapore Airlines has **31** of the type on order, is not first in line, and Boeing expects first deliveries in 2027. No launch routes have been named.[2]

Elsewhere in the schedule, two retreats. **Dubai slips again**: SQ494 and SQ495 are cancelled through **28 February 2027** against a previous target of 2 December, the airline citing the Middle East; the route has been suspended since February. And the **A380 comes off Frankfurt for summer 2027**, cutting weekly seats each way from 5,145 to 3,696 — **28 per cent** — with first-class capacity down a fifth and economy down 30. Suites passengers drop to the 2013 first seat, four of them, no doors. **Heathrow keeps two daily A380s at the same redemption price.**[3]



Every cabin narrows. A *Meridian* figure from the airline's published widths; business is the A350 pair, the other two the 777-9 against the 777-300ER.[2]

-6 in

BUSINESS-CLASS WIDTH ON THE A350, 28 INCHES DOWN TO 22[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE REVIEWERS SAID ABOUT THE NEW CABIN

The trade reaction to Singapore Airlines' 2027 cabin was unusually unanimous and unusually rude. **Rhys Jones** of Head for Points called it "virtually unrecognisable as a Singapore Airlines seat". **Ben Schlappig** read it as a mix of Scoot and Spirit. **Edward Russell** called it a clear misstep with low-cost-carrier overtones. **Mateusz Maszczynski** of PYOK said he had not seen an uglier new business seat in a long time. The airline's position is that it follows no fixed colour palette; Mainly Miles judges the seat itself settled and the colours still open to revision. **First class was broadly well received. Reddit refused every desk in this issue, so no flyer forum appears here.**[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE WIDTH CUT MAY NOT BE WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

A seat width is not a measurement until someone says where it was taken. Airlines quote business-class width at different points — between armrests, across the cushion, at the shoulder — and a suite with a door is measured differently from an open seat. The 28-inch figure attaches to a 2013 product on a cabin that carried fewer passengers; the honest comparison is not width alone but width, pitch, privacy and the bed. And the loudest critics are reviewing a mock-up in a hall, not a seat in a cabin, eighteen months before anyone sits in one in flight. **What would settle it:** a published seat map with a bed length, and the first review from an actual rotation.[2]

SOURCES 1 Mainly Miles' report of 7 November 2026, read at source, for the 6 November unveiling at Marina Bay Sands, the second-half-2027 timing, the mineral grey and "Cool Yellow" scheme and its naming, the four named reviewers and their quoted or paraphrased verdicts, the airline's response on palettes, the publication's own judgement that the colours remain open, the reception of first class, and the 22-inch A350 and 24-inch 777-9 widths against 28 inches on the 2013 seat and 25 on the Qantas comparison. 2 Mainly Miles' report of 6 November 2026, read at source, for the premium-economy and economy configurations, pitches, widths, recline and screen sizes, the 777-9 exclusivity and the A350 refresh, the 31 aircraft on order, the delivery expectation and the absence of named launch routes. **A widely syndicated route table still lists the Dubai restart as 24 October 2026; it did not happen.**

DEPARTURES · THE JOHOR BAHRU RAIL LINK

The Johor Bahru rail link slipped from end-2026 to February 2027

RTS Operations announced the new target on 2 October. Testing should finish by 31 December; the date and the fares will come from two ministers jointly.

The rail link between Johor Bahru and Woodlands will not open this year, and the slip this desk has flagged for months is now on the record: the operator has moved its target to February 2027. All system testing and trial running is still expected to finish by **31 December**; February covers remaining works, third-party safety certification and approvals from both governments.[1]

What is missing is everything a traveller can act on. **There is no opening date and there are no fares.** Both will be announced jointly by the two transport ministers, and neither has been set. Singapore's **Jeffrey Siow** said on 3 October that certification and licensing were meant to conclude by year-end. The project was announced in **May 2010** for 2018, declared behind schedule in 2019, suspended at Malaysia's request, resumed in July 2020, and given an end-2026 date as recently as July 2025.[1]

On the entry-rules front, the useful news is negative. **Europe's entry-exit system has been fully operational since 10 April**, so biometric registration at the border is now routine across 29 countries. Its travel-authorisation counterpart **is still not open and has no announced launch date**; the late-2026 window was removed from the official portal. **You cannot apply, and any site taking applications today is not legitimate.** Thailand's flat **450-baht** arrival fee was endorsed in August and is **not being collected**; Bali's levy stays at **150,000 rupiah**, enforced by spot-check, with no fine in law.[2]

1.5 mpd

THE REFRESHED AMEX KRISFLYER ASCEND BASE RATE, FROM 1.2, FROM 1 NOVEMBER[3]

THE CHATTER · A CORRECTION ON THE SPANISH STRIKES

Travel media have spent the week warning of Spanish air-traffic-control strikes on 10 and 17 November. **This desk could find no source for either date, and prints the correction rather than the warning.** What genuinely exists is two separate things. First, a **24-hour nationwide general strike on Wednesday 11 November**, called by the CCOO and UGT unions; ground staff, controllers and cabin crew may all join, Spanish workers need not declare participation in advance, and as of 4 November the transport ministry had not published minimum services for air transport. Second, a separate **open-ended controllers' strike since April at towers run by a private contractor**, with minimum services set at 73 per cent for November on inter-island flights from Lanzarote, where delays have run since 4 November. **Compensation note:** strikes of this kind are generally treated as extraordinary circumstances, so fixed compensation is usually not owed — but refund and rebooking rights stand.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE FEBRUARY RAIL DATE SHOULD NOT BE BOOKED AROUND

A target announced by the operator is not a date announced by the two ministers who have reserved the right to announce it. This project has now missed 2018, a post-2024 warning, an end-2026 target and a December opening, and the remaining tasks — third-party safety certification and two governments' approvals — are exactly the kind that do not run to schedule. February is also four months of testing away, and no fare has been set, which means no revenue model has been agreed. **What would settle it:** a joint ministerial announcement with a date and a fare table in it. Until then, do not plan a February crossing around a train.[1]

IN BRIEF

Qatar Airways' Changi lounge went daily. From 25 October the Terminal 1 morning session runs **07:15–10:15 every day** instead of four days a week, and the evening session now opens at **17:15**, 35 minutes earlier. Access needs a Qatar or oneworld first or business boarding card: **status alone does not get you in.**[5]

SOURCES 1 AsiaOne's account of the link's timeline, read at source, for the operator's 2 October 2026 announcement of a February 2027 target, the expectation that testing concludes by 31 December, the remaining works, the third-party certification and both grantors' approvals, the joint ministerial announcement of date and fares, the transport minister's 3 October remarks, and the slippage record from May 2010. 4 A travel-industry report, read at source, for the 11 November general strike, the unions calling it, the absence of published minimum services as at 4 November and the compensation position; the separate contractor-tower strike and its minimum-service percentages are secondary. **This desk could reach neither the transport ministry nor the airport or air-navigation authorities, and found no source at all for a strike on 10 or 17 November.** 5 Mainly Miles, 26 October 2026, read at source. 6 An Indian business title, read at source, for the Udaipur winter schedule and the new services.

THE GRAND TOUR · JAIPUR AND UDAIPUR

Rajasthan's only sensible season opened a week ago, and Pushkar runs 17 November

Jaipur averages 29.6°C and 1.9mm of rain in November, against 41.1°C in May. The camel fair closes on Kartik Purnima, eight days from now.

The state of Rajasthan has four months in which a visitor should go and eight in which they should not, and the four began a week ago. Jaipur's November mean daily maximum is **29.6°C** with **1.9mm** of rain — statistically dry, shirt weather by day, a layer at breakfast. Udaipur is 29.8°C and 5.2mm. This book's first Indian deep dive is timed to it.[1]

Know what you are avoiding. **Jaipur's May mean daily maximum is 41.1°C** — a monthly average, not a spike, against a record of 49.0. June is worse in one way, because the nights stop recovering: the mean minimum is **27.9°C**. Then the monsoon takes **394mm in July and August alone, two-thirds of the annual 600mm**. The forts are exposed stone with no shade. And for anyone planning January: Jaipur's mean minimum is **8.4°C**, with a record of −2.2, and **Udaipur's is colder still at 7.6**. That is eight degrees in an unheated stone room with marble floors at half past six. People underpack for it every year.[1]

Now the correction nobody prints. November in north India is smog season, and the comfortable story is that Jaipur is not Delhi. On the day this desk checked, **Delhi's air quality index read 376 and Jaipur's 185** — roughly half, two bands better. But the Centre for Science and Environment's analysis of the regulator's data found something sharper: Jaipur's bad-air episodes are **longer and more persistent** than Delhi's, which rise and fall faster. In November 2020 Jaipur held a weekly average above 120 micrograms for **six consecutive days**, which it had never done before. **Udaipur is materially cleaner** — its rise that November was the smallest of any Rajasthani city listed, 8 per cent against Jaipur's 26 — because it sits 400km south-west, outside the plume.[2]

So weight the trip towards Udaipur and keep Jaipur short: two nights in Jaipur, three or four in Udaipur, the walled city in the mornings, and masks in the bag. That is what the data support and, independently, what the forums say.[2]

17–24 Nov

THE PUSHKAR CAMEL FAIR, CONFIRMED ON INDIA'S OWN TOURISM PORTAL; NO TICKET REQUIRED[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT TRAVELLERS SAY ABOUT JAIPUR AND UDAIPUR

The most consistent finding in the whole corpus is a preference. On the **TripAdvisor Rajasthan forum**: "Numerous people just visit the Golden Triangle ... and here the touts are the most aggressive. Of course they work also in the rest of the state but in towns like Jodhpur, Jaisalmer, Udaipur and Bundi the situation is much better." And flatly, "Jaipur was by far the worst for touts." On **Fodor's**, posters repeatedly pick Udaipur for the lake, the Aravalli hills and the ease of day trips, calling the city "much lower key"; one found Jaipur "overwhelming and very tourist-driven". **Has it improved? This desk does not know and will not pretend to: almost everything reachable dates from 2013 to 2024.** The only 2026 signal points the other way — a verified-guide app launched at Amer Fort in May. **Reddit refused every desk in this issue; TripAdvisor and Fodor's both returned 403, so these are verbatim snippets with the page but not the poster or the date.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE PUSHKAR FAIR MAY NOT BE THE FAIR YOU BOOKED

The camels are going. Rajasthan's camel population fell from about **420,000 in 2007 to roughly 210,000 in the 2019 census**, and herders tie it to a 2015 law restricting movement of camels out of the state plus a generation uninterested in herding. One travel account is blunt: the fair "definitely isn't what it used to be... much more commercialized and tourist-focused". **The useful resolution is timing:** a 2026 guide calls it "a really busy trade show for the vendors, a regular fair for the locals, and a slightly disorganized cultural event for visitors... still worth checking out". **So go 17 to 19 November for the livestock fair, or 23 to 24 for the Kartik Purnima bathing.** Not the middle.[5]

SOURCES 1 India Meteorological Department 1991–2020 normals for Jaipur and Udaipur, read in the standard encyclopaedic rendering of the IMD tables rather than at the department's own files, for every monthly mean maximum, mean minimum and rainfall figure quoted, the annual totals and the record extremes. **Secondary sources give 17–25 November and an outlier that is simply wrong; dates follow the lunar calendar.** 4 The TripAdvisor Rajasthan forum and Fodor's Rajasthan thread. **Both hosts returned 403 to every direct request across four domains, so the quotations are verbatim search extracts carrying the page but not the username or date, and the 2026 guide app is the only current-year signal located.** 5 Livestock census figures and the herders' explanation from an Indian current-affairs outlet, read at source; the two traveller characterisations from named 2021 and 2026 travel accounts, read at source.

THE GRAND TOUR · JANTAR MANTAR

The great sundial of Jaipur claims two seconds and blurs by twelve

The Vrihat Samrat Yantra is 27 metres high and ruled at two-second intervals. The standard reference site says the shadow edge spans six or seven of those marks.

The most repeated fact about Jaipur is that Jai Singh II's giant stone sundial tells the time to two seconds, and it is the conventional wisdom this desk would most like to correct. The **Vrihat Samrat Yantra**, completed in 1734 and **27 metres high**, has its gnomon angled at **27 degrees**, Jaipur's latitude; its shadow crosses the quadrants at about **a millimetre a second**, on scales graduated at two-second intervals.[1]

Then comes the physics. Because the gnomon's edge stands well back from the scale, the shadow has a soft edge — and the standard reference site on the observatory states that this edge **"may span 6-7 of these marks"**. That is twelve to fourteen seconds of blur on a scale ruled at two. The sun's penumbra can be **30mm** wide, making millimetre graduations "practically insignificant". Nor is the stone Jai Singh's: the site became a gun factory, had lead added to its lines in 1876, was re-faced in 1901–02 with different materials, and has since subsided enough to misalign the instruments.[1]

The two-second figure is a design intent carved into stone, not a measured performance — and it is recoverable, which is the best ten minutes you will spend there with a child. Hold a thin rod a centimetre above the quadrant, parallel to the shadow's edge; where the rod's own shadow disappears marks the centre of the blur. What is extraordinary at Jantar Mantar is not the accuracy but the idea: that the way to make an instrument more precise is to build it at the scale of architecture.[1]

Getting there, and the money fact that matters. There is no nonstop from Singapore to either city; the working shape is Singapore to Delhi overnight, Delhi to Jaipur first thing, Jaipur to Udaipur by road, home via Mumbai. A good routing is ten and a half to twelve hours and a careless one doubles it. On the visa: a Singapore passport pays **US$25 for the one-year multiple-entry e-visa**, where nearly every other nationality on the government's own fee table pays US$40 — **the same US$25 as the thirty-day** for November-to-March travel. **Two traps:** the e-visa works only at designated airports, and **Jaipur is listed while Udaipur is not**; and pay only on the government site.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHERE TO SLEEP, AND WHAT TRAVELLERS SAY IT BUYS

The sharpest advice in the corpus, from the **TripAdvisor Jaipur forum**, is to take the cheaper heritage option in Jaipur **"and maybe investing that difference to stay in a structure on the lake in Udaipur"**. Save in Jaipur, spend in Udaipur. From the Udaipur forum: "the beauty is all around the lake"; the old city "is the best place to stay as you may walk around easily". **Jagat Niwas** is the most-named property and tops TripAdvisor's heritage value ranking for "authentic heritage character that feels lived-in rather than recreated" — the test to apply to every property on the list. **None of the flagship palaces publishes a rate: this desk read the Oberoi and Leela pages in full and all list categories and no prices.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE JAIPUR AND UDAIPUR UNDERWHELM

Hawa Mahal's interior is the sight to skip, and the dissent is now mainstream: "There are far more impressive sights to explore while in Jaipur, and you can skip the entire thing and watch the famous facade of the palace from the street level" — and the defence concedes the diagnosis, "The front facade is really the main reason to go." Jantar Mantar without a guide "loses a lot of meaning"; reviewers report about **400 rupees** for one. **On the elephant rides at Amer: there is no ban, and nobody should take one.** A committee under India's environment ministry has recommended phasing them out on grounds of the animals' age; welfare bodies cite tuberculosis among them; ten were withdrawn in 2018 with an infectious disease. **Those welfare claims are advocacy groups' and this desk could not second-source the committee's status** — but no ban exists, and anyone writing that one does is wrong.[4]

SOURCES 1 The standard reference site on the Jaipur observatory, read at source, for the two-second graduation, the quoted criticism that the shadow "may span 6-7 of these marks" and the rod technique for recovering the centre; the encyclopaedic article on Jantar Mantar, read at source, for the 1734 completion, the 27-metre height and 27-degree gnomon, the millimetre-per-second shadow, the roughly 30mm penumbra and the "practically insignificant" judgement, the nineteen instruments, the 2010 UNESCO inscription, and the restoration history from the gun factory through 1876 and 1901–02 to the subsidence. **That page contradicts itself on how many airports are designated; Jaipur appears in its main list and Udaipur does not. 4 Hawa Mahal and Jantar Mantar visitor quotations are verbatim search extracts from TripAdvisor reviews. The state ticketing portal would not resolve, so no admission price is printed.**

THE DIARY · THE DECEMBER KABUKI

Kabukiza puts December's tickets on sale at ten o'clock on 14 November

Seats run from ¥4,500 to ¥17,000 across three daily programmes, and anyone aged 30 or under can buy a half-price same-day seat.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

28 NOV ★ **BABYMONSTER · [출 CHOOM] world tour**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · DOORS 4.30PM, SHOW 6PM · **S$168 TO S$358** BEFORE A TIERED BOOKING FEE · GENERAL SALE OPENED 11 JUNE; THE VENUE PAGE STILL SHOWS A LIVE BUY TICKETS BUTTON[1]

17–22 Dec ★ **BTS · ARIRANG, four nights**
NATIONAL STADIUM · 17, 19, 20 AND 22 DECEMBER · **FACE VALUE S$148 TO S$388**, NOW READABLE AT THE VENUE FOR THE FIRST TIME · **THE TOURISM BOARD'S OWN RELEASE CALLS THE RUN SOLD OUT**; TIMES STILL TO BE CONFIRMED[2]

1–31 Dec **BTS THE CITY ARIRANG · city-wide**
JEWEL, MANDAI, THE NATIONAL GALLERY, THE NATIONAL MUSEUM, SENTOSA, RESORTS WORLD AND ZOUK · MARINA BAY AND THE RIVER LIT IN RED **8–22 DECEMBER** · **NO PRICING PUBLISHED**[2]

12 Nov–27 Dec **Monkey Goes West · Wild Rice**
NGEE ANN KONGSI THEATRE, FUNAN · **S$50 TO S$120** BY NIGHT AND TIER · RECOMMENDED FOR AGES FIVE AND UP — THE FAMILY BOOKING OF THE SEASON · BOTH DISCOUNT WINDOWS HAVE CLOSED[3]

18 Nov–6 Dec ***Eureka Day* · Singapore Repertory Theatre**
KC ARTS CENTRE · **S$48 TO S$78**, YOUTH TICKETS **S$28** FOR 25 AND UNDER · ADVISORY FOR MATURE CONTENT AND COARSE LANGUAGE — **NOT THE FAMILY ROW**[4]

4–6 Dec **BYD Singapore International Marathon**
F1 PIT BUILDING TO THE NATIONAL STADIUM · **REGISTRATION CLOSED 30 SEPTEMBER**, MARATHON AND HALF SOLD OUT · NOTE THE TITLE SPONSOR HAS CHANGED — STANDARD CHARTERED NOW BACKS THE 10KM ONLY[5]

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

2–25 Dec ★ **December Grand Kabuki · tickets 14 Nov**
KABUKIZA, TOKYO · **SALE OPENS 10AM ON 14 NOVEMBER** · **¥4,500 TO ¥17,000** · THREE PROGRAMMES DAILY FROM 11AM, 2.30PM AND 6PM; DARK ON 9 AND 17 DECEMBER · **HALF-PRICE SAME-DAY SEATS FOR UNDER-31S**[6]

2–26 Jan **New Year Grand Kabuki · tickets 14 Dec**
KABUKIZA, TOKYO · DAY FROM 11AM, NIGHT FROM 4.30PM; DARK ON 8 AND 18 JANUARY · **PRICES NOT YET PUBLISHED** — DECEMBER'S GRID IS THE ONLY GUIDE[6]

4–11 Feb **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, TSUDŌMU AND SUSUKINO · FREE AT ODORI AND SUSUKINO · **THE JAPANESE PAGE CARRIES THE 2027 DATES; THE ENGLISH PAGE STILL SHOWS 2025** — INDEPENDENTLY CONFIRMED AGAIN THIS WEEK[7]

6 DEC ***Daitokuji: A Zen Temple Beyond Compare* closes**
TOKYO NATIONAL MUSEUM, HEISEIKAN · **¥2,300 ADULT, ¥900 HIGH SCHOOL** · THE 700TH ANNIVERSARY SHOW; THE TICKET ALSO ADMITS YOU TO THE COLLECTION GALLERIES THAT DAY[8]

28 NOV **Nozawa Onsen · 2026–27 season opens**
NAGANO · THE RESORT'S OWN PUBLISHED OPENING DATE, WITH AN EARLY-SEASON PERIOD TO 18 DECEMBER · **NO LIFT-PASS PRICE ON THAT PAGE**[9]

PLANNING NOTES

One date beats the others: 14 November. Kabukiza's December sale opens at ten that morning, and it is the only row here whose window opens after this issue. **The BTS thread, held for months, is half-resolved** — the face-value grid is readable at the venue at last, S$148 to S$388, but the tourism board describes the run as sold out, so the prices are a record rather than an instruction.

And the one that got away again. Christmas Wonderland runs 27 November to 3 January, and this desk made four fresh attempts at a ticket price today: the organiser's what's-on pages render unfilled template placeholders, the attraction page 404s, and both ticketing subdomains serve navigation only. **The position is unchanged, and the figures aggregators quote are not the organiser's.**[10]

SOURCES 1–5 The Kallang's own venue event pages, read at source on 8–9 November 2026, for every Singapore concert and race entry: the BABYMONSTER date, times, full price grid and booking-fee tiers (**the listing header shows a two-day span while its body states 28 November; the single date is printed**); the BTS ARIRANG four nights, the full face-value grid and the booking fees, with the Singapore Tourism Board's own release, read at source, for the sold-out description and the city-wide programme, its venues and the 8–22 December light-up, which publishes no pricing; Wild Rice's own page for *Monkey Goes West*'s run to 27 December, its four price tiers and the age recommendation (**a secondary listing gives 13 December; the organiser's own date is used**); the Singapore Repertory Theatre's own page for *Eureka Day*; and The Kallang's page for the marathon, its programme, its closed registration and the sponsor change. 9 Nozawa Onsen's own site, read at source. **Esplanade returned 503 on four attempts, SISTIC served an empty shell returning zero results, Marina Bay Sands 503, Ticketmaster and the Sports Hub 403, and the orchestra's pages 404 — so several events reported elsewhere this week are deliberately absent rather than printed unconfirmed.**

THE TABLE · FIVE NEW OPENINGS

Lee Haedong, 24, opens the Korean dining bar JJAN on Craig Road

He toured Korean breweries to build a list of more than 30 makgeolli and yakju. His chef, Yoo Gwangsoo, came from two-starred Saint Pierre.

JJAN, at 45 Craig Road, is a modern Korean dining bar named after the drinking toast, and it is built backwards from the drinks. The menu follows *juansang*, the Korean practice of pairing dishes to what is in the glass; there is no set menu. Founder **Lee Haedong**, 24, who also runs concepts in Seoul, built the list himself from Korean breweries — more than thirty makgeolli and traditional liquors from **S$12** a glass. Chef **Yoo Gwangsoo**, 39, was a sous chef at two-starred Saint Pierre.[1]

Dishes run **S$6 to S$80**: Busan jijimi with squid salad S$18, pork gukbap S$21, binchotan-grilled beef tongue S$58, hanger steak S$80. Open 5pm to midnight on weekdays, from 1pm at weekends. **Too new to call:** no independent review exists, the only coverage is a first look that discloses it was a hosted tasting, and even the opening date is disputed between 9 and 12 November. Go for the makgeolli flight, early, on a weeknight.[1]

The firmest date belongs to **HI BOWL**, which opened on **3 November** at Wilkie Edge — Haidilao's malatang spin-off, not a Haidilao outlet. You pick from more than a hundred ingredients and pay **S$2.98 per 100g**, with all five soup bases and both dry mixes included, which is the competitive hook; skewers S$1 to S$1.50. Not halal-certified. It runs to 1am, which makes it the useful one. **Also too new to call:** this desk searched for queue reports and Singapore opinion and found none. **The only review-shaped thing located was about a Toronto branch, and it is not reported.**[2]

One with an actual verdict. **Three Bowls** at Whampoa Makan Place does Sabah-style kolo mee, darker and more savoury than the Sarawak version, under **Robin Lee**, previously a chef at one of Singapore's best-known Taiwanese dumpling chains; the pork chop kolo mee is **S$6.90**. Eatbook's **Edna Low** reports it has "built a solid fanbase with long queues every day" and calls it the cheaper route to that chain's pork chop. **Honesty flag: that outlet calls it only "relatively new" and publishes no opening date.** Closed Tuesdays.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE DISSENT ON ACCOMPANY COFFEE'S OLIVE OIL CAKE

Accompany Coffee is a family-run nook inside Grafunkt's showroom at 292 Joo Chiat Road — the barista is one family member, his daughter does the bakes. Blacks S$5.50, house cheesecake S$8.50, citrus olive oil cake S$7.50; weekdays 10am to 4.30pm. HungryGoWhere's **Evan Mua** calls the setting "gorgeous" and rates the cheesecake **among the best he has had at a cafe** — then reports the dissent himself: on the olive oil cake, **"some customers found it too burnt"**. His verdict is measured rather than a rave. **Honesty flag: the piece is dated 6 November but says the cafe has had the space since August. Reddit, Burpple, SETHLUI, Time Out and the Michelin listings all refused this desk.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY FOUR OF THIS MONTH'S "NEW" OPENINGS WERE NOT

The monthly round-ups are recycling: the first eight candidates this desk checked held four stale entries, three by more than a year. One Dempsey restaurant appeared under November 2026 and had been reviewed in June; a pizzeria ran in an October round-up and had opened in **May 2025**. The lesson for anyone reading a list headed by the current month: **a venue appearing in it is not evidence that it opened in it.** Every name above was date-checked against a second source.[5]

And one opening imminently. Yee3, a Shanghai coconut-drink brand with more than 500 outlets and queues reported in Kuala Lumpur and Sydney, takes a basement counter at ION Orchard in **mid-November. No Singapore price has been announced — both signature items are listed as to be confirmed, and the Chinese range is not a Singapore price.** The lesson from those other openings is that the first fortnight is the worst; to taste it, go in December.[6]

SOURCES 1 HungryGoWhere's first look at JJAN, read at source, for the address, the *juansang* concept, the founder's age and Seoul concepts, the chef's name, age and previous kitchen, the drinks list and glass prices, every dish price quoted and the opening hours. **That piece discloses it was a hosted tasting and is not treated as a review. 5 Date checks against second sources for each rejected venue, read at source. 6 Eatbook's November round-up, read at source, for Yee3's mid-November opening, the ION Orchard address, the Shanghai origin, the outlet count, the reported Kuala Lumpur and Sydney queues, the five-million-cup figure and the absence of Singapore pricing. That entry is an explicit preview with no tasting and no verdict. Every venue above was checked against this issue's 131-name barred list before selection.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · CHINA'S AI MANJU

China made 221,900 AI cartoon dramas in six months and the pay collapsed

Revenue per ten thousand views fell from 30–100 yuan to 5–10. One maker's eleven series, sixteen episodes each, earned 9.60 yuan in total.

In the first half of this year, Chinese studios released 221,900 new animated serials onto a single app — more than 1,200 episodes a day, one new title roughly every 36 seconds at the peak — and almost all of them were made by artificial intelligence. For comparison, the whole country produced 33,000 live-action micro-dramas in all of 2025. In the same window, what a view was worth fell by up to ninety per cent.[1]

The thing being made is called 漫剧, *mànjù* — literally comic-drama, glossed in the Chinese trade press as a "visualised novel". A web novel becomes a vertical animated serial of fifty-second episodes. There is no cast, no crew, no location and no permit. A hundred-minute title that would cost 400,000 to 500,000 yuan and take 25 to 40 days as live action costs about **110,000 yuan** and takes seven to fifteen. The word is not a journalist's coinage: it is a tab in an app, and three of China's largest platforms run dedicated *mànjù* sections.[2]

This is the first complete, national-scale experiment in what happens when generative artificial intelligence collapses the cost of making something inside a market where one company also sets the price of the result. The answer is that **the productivity gain never reaches the producer**. It passes straight through to whoever controls distribution. That is the argument of this essay, and the evidence for it is a pair of numbers that move together.[3]

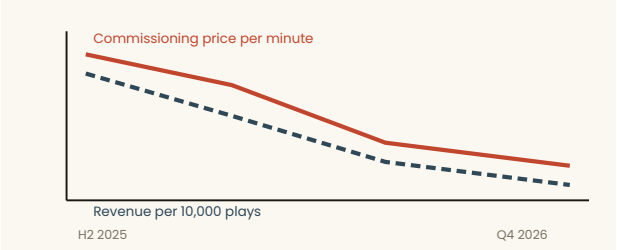
Here they are. Cost per minute of production fell by somewhere between sixty and ninety per cent in about a year: commissioning prices slid from 1,500–2,000 yuan a minute in early 2026 to mostly under 1,000 by late March, and assembly-line quotes from around 5,000 to a few hundred. Over the same window, **revenue per ten thousand plays fell from 30–100 yuan in the second half of 2025 to 5–10 yuan**. Those are not two findings. They are one event seen from both ends.[1]

Eleven series. Sixteen episodes each. Nine yuan sixty.

The hit rate is the other half of it. Of the 221,900 titles released in the first half of the year, **1,055 passed a hundred million plays** — 0.47 per cent. Against the industry analyst's assumed break-even of fifty million plays, **2,886 recovered their cost: fewer than one in seventy-seven**. A report on Chinese artificial intelligence in film and television found that as of 28 February, of 127,800 titles streaming, **fewer than 150 had passed a hundred million views**. One practitioner's accounting, reported in August, is the detail that stays with you: eleven series, sixteen episodes each, total earnings **9.6 yuan**.[1]

1 in 77

TITLES RECOVERING COST, AGAINST THE ANALYST'S FIFTY-MILLION-PLAY BREAK-EVEN[1]



Both curves fall together: the cost of making a *mànjù* and the revenue a view returns. A *Meridian* figure, drawn from the sourced ranges on this page rather than from a continuous series.[1]

SOURCES 1 DataEye's first-half 2026 figures as carried by two Chinese business outlets, both pages read at source, for the 221,900 titles released natively in the first half, the implied daily and per-36-second rates, the 33,000 live-action titles in all of 2025, the hundredfold rise in monthly new releases, the fall in revenue per ten thousand plays from 30–100 to 5–10 yuan, the 1,055 titles past a hundred million plays and the 2,886 past the assumed fifty-million break-even, the commissioning-price slide and the practitioner's 9.6 yuan. The 127,800-titles-and-under-150 figure is from a 2025–26 industry report as carried by a Chinese outlet's English service, read at source. **The break-even line is DataEye's assumption, not an observed figure, and its sample is one platform, which that report concedes understates the true share.** 2 Two Chinese business outlets, both read at source, for the term *mànjù* and its trade gloss, the dedicated platform sections, the web-novel source material and the cost and schedule comparison against live action. 3 The argument is this desk's, assembled from the figures in note 1 and the mechanism set out on p26.

The mechanism is a formula, and the formula has a term in it that nobody outside one company has ever seen. ByteDance's free short-drama app, **Hóngguǒ** — Red Fruit — moved its creators from a guaranteed floor plus a revenue share to a pure share, calculated as **total watch time × unit price × coefficient**. Neither the unit price nor the coefficient is published. A producer named **Yuan Min** told a Shanghai newspaper that after a coefficient change, a title he expected to bring in over a million yuan came in at **100,000 to 200,000**.[1]

That single line is the essay. A platform sets, unilaterally and without disclosure, a multiplier that determines the entire revenue of every producer on it, and can change it after the work is made. The producer is the only party in the chain carrying inventory risk and the only one whose price is set by somebody else.[1]

Because every other link belongs to the same company. The intellectual property comes from ByteDance's web-fiction arm. The video model and compute come from ByteDance, billed per second — and when it upgraded, **the price per second went up, from about one yuan to 2.1**, so a title now costs 18,000 to 30,000 yuan in compute alone. The traffic comes from ByteDance's ad platform, and buying it is about **seventy per cent** of a producer's cost. The money returns through Hóngguǒ, under a formula ByteDance writes. **The only two prices that moved in the producer's favour were the ones ByteDance did not set.**[2]

And the binding constraint was never creation. It was attention, and attention did not get cheaper. In 2025 China made 46,931 of these and they drew over 70 billion views. In the first quarter of 2026 alone it made 128,000 and they drew about 130 billion. **Output multiplied an order of magnitude faster than viewing**, and the surplus had nowhere to go except into the price. Mature teams now run a return on their traffic spend of **1.03 to 1.07** — a margin of three to seven per cent.[2]

The state wrote the cost collapse into statute before the market had finished consolidating.

The regulator understood this before the industry did, and priced it. On 25 June the broadcasting administration issued a classification standard for AI micro-dramas, effective 1 July, with filing tiers set by investment: **800,000 yuan** and above for the top tier, **300,000 to 800,000** for the middle. The equivalent live-action thresholds, effective on 1 January this year, are **3 million and 1 million**. The AI thresholds are roughly **thirty per cent** of the live-action ones. That is a bureaucracy, measuring the same thing in the same units four years apart, recording a seventy per cent cost deflation without anyone having to estimate it. **The state's filing threshold is an unintentional, officially stamped price index for the collapse.**[3]

It is also an analogy that does not need decorating. Live-action micro-drama took about four years to go from a recognised thing to a classification regime. AI *mànjù* took two. One trade outlet's line is the whole history: AI *mànjù* covered in a single year the road the short-drama industry took four years to travel.[3]

30%

AI FILING THRESHOLDS AGAINST LIVE-ACTION: 800,000 YUAN VERSUS 3 MILLION[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT MANJU MAKERS TOLD THE CHINESE PRESS

A Shanghai paper's three-part series on the industry, published in May under the headline **"Ninety per cent of AI manju lose money, and people keep coming"**, carries the voices. **Gong Bingzhi**, co-founder of a Zhengzhou studio, gave the ninety-per-cent figure as his own rough estimate: "ninety per cent of people in this market are losing money"; his team treats ten million plays as a weak result. **Liu Yuan** on why everybody switched: Hóngguǒ "suddenly changed the guarantee policy, so we had no choice but to put everything into AI". **Wang Guanghui**, whose sixty-strong team made over 400 titles in the month around Spring Festival, on the only metric that matters: "if a drama hasn't hooked the user in the first fifteen seconds, it basically has no hope". And a former director, under a pseudonym: "low cost is what the platforms and the bosses want; no other reason matters". **These are reported quotations in Chinese outlets this desk read, not interviews it conducted.**[4]

SOURCES 1 A Shanghai newspaper's report of 13 May 2026, read at source through its publisher's mobile edition, for the move from a guaranteed floor to a pure revenue share, the three-term formula, the fact that neither the unit price nor the coefficient is published, and the named producer's account of a title falling from an expected million-plus to 100,000–200,000 yuan after a coefficient change. 3 A Chinese business outlet's report of 28 June 2026, read at source, for the classification standard issued 25 June and effective 1 July, its 800,000 and 300,000 yuan tiers, the live-action thresholds of 3 million and 1 million effective 1 January 2026, and the quoted four-years-in-one line. **The thirty and seventy per cent figures are this desk's arithmetic on those published thresholds.** 4 The same Shanghai newspaper's series, read in full at source, for its headline and for every named practitioner quotation. **Reddit and Weibo itself are unreachable to this desk; all platform sentiment in this essay is reported in Chinese outlets that were read, and none is quoted at first hand.**

The format itself mutated to fit the formula. Because the payout is a function of total watch time and retention is front-loaded, episodes have been sliced thinner and series stretched longer. One title now runs to **788 episodes**; its first four run over a minute and from the fifth they settle at about **fifty seconds**. Another opened its twelfth season at 1.37 in the morning with the highest heat value in the platform's history and has passed **six billion cumulative plays**. In the August top hundred, every one of the hundred slots was held by the same sub-genre.[1]

Then the platform began throttling what it had created. In July the dedicated section vanished for some users in a grey test, read by one outlet as capacity control. And at its own industry conference ByteDance announced over **1.5 billion yuan** of guaranteed support for live-action, with average per-title funding up about sixty per cent and up to 1.5 million yuan for top titles. Having competed humans out, it started paying to bring them back.[2]

The export is under way, and it lands in this region. AI drama is forecast to take nearly **seventy per cent of the overseas micro-drama market** in 2026, at over **four billion US dollars**. Short-drama app downloads rose 140 per cent year on year in the first quarter, with **Southeast Asia taking 32 per cent**. Daily use reached **25 minutes** globally by April, up 85 per cent in fifteen months — and in Southeast Asia approached **forty minutes**. The payout architecture travels with the format.[3]

A market whose revenue grows 138 per cent is not being destroyed. It is being consolidated.

What would falsify the argument? Four things, and they are worth watching. If the rate per ten thousand plays **stabilises or recovers while output stays high**, the collapse was a supply overshoot clearing, not an extraction. If ByteDance **publishes the unit price and the coefficient**, the opacity-as-mechanism claim fails outright and the arrangement becomes an ordinary piece rate. If a studio reaches durable profitability **outside ByteDance distribution** — overseas, on its own app — then the bottleneck was never structural. And if live-action margins recover now that 1.5 billion yuan is buying humans back, the platform is managing a portfolio rather than harvesting a category.[4]

It is being regulated in real time. On **6 November** the broadcasting administration is reported to have opened a two-month campaign against quality problems in AI short dramas; by 27 October Hóngguǒ had removed **20,426** titles. **This desk could not confirm that campaign at the regulator's own site, whose notices page returns an empty placeholder, and prints it as single-sourced.** The direction is not in doubt: a category that did not exist in 2024 now has its own statute, enforcement campaign and deletion counts.[5]

The sceptic's case deserves the last word before the verdict. A fair reading is that this is an ordinary gold rush, badly measured, told from the losers' side. The aggregate is up: the app's daily users rose 107 per cent year on year to 168 million in July, more than four major Chinese streaming services combined, and the analyst has the market growing 138 per cent. The ninety-per-cent loss figure traces to **one studio co-founder's rough estimate**. The market sizes do not agree — 40 billion yuan, 24 billion, 121 billion on a broader definition — **and the firm publishing the largest is an advertising-intelligence vendor whose customers are this market's buyers**. And a ninety per cent fall in revenue per view, in a year when titles rose a hundredfold, is close to what a competitive market does unaided.[6]

Which is why the coefficient is the test. Every other fact here is consistent with both stories. Only one thing distinguishes a market clearing from a margin being taken, and it is whether the party setting the price will say what the price is. Until then the honest verdict is narrower than the headline and more useful: China has shown that collapsing the cost of production does not, by itself, enrich anyone who produces. It enriches whoever owns the road to the audience — and in this case that was the same company that sold the tools, the stories, the traffic and the compute, with the compute going up in price while everything else went down.[4]

SOURCES 1 Chinese business outlets, read at source, for the 788-episode title and its episode lengths, the twelfth-season launch with the platform's highest recorded heat value and the six-billion-play cumulative figure, and for the August top-hundred composition. **The conference date is not confirmed and is not printed.** 3 A technology outlet, read at source, for the overseas forecast of over four billion dollars and nearly seventy per cent share, the first-quarter download growth and regional shares, and the daily-usage figures including the Southeast Asian figure. 4 The falsification tests and the closing verdict are this desk's. 5 A single English-language outlet, read at source, for the 6 November campaign and the 20,426 removals. **The characterisation of the analyst as an advertising-intelligence vendor is this desk's reading of its own stated business, and the concern that its market size may fold in advertising spend is an inference, not a finding. Searches aimed squarely at the major Western outlets surfaced no feature on this subject; a United States business broadcaster's August piece mentions the term once, inside a market-size line, and never defines it.**

THE LAST WORD

The number nobody published

Phillips finished the most watched watch sale in the world on Sunday afternoon and did not say what it made. So this desk downloaded all 225 lot entries, added the 211 published results and got **CHF 91,922,250** — a floor, not a total, because ten lots carry no result at all (p10). That is the whole issue in one act.

M1 and Doctor Anywhere have let a third day pass without saying how many customers their breaches exposed, and M1 names no regulator (p5). Commerce stayed its own export rule for 62 days and gave no reason (p7). Raspberry Pi raised a price by eighty dollars without printing the old one (p8). Audio-Technica put a $3,799 flagship in front of a roomful of listeners and has still published no measurement (p10). Japan's own weekend figure for the film that won America does not exist yet (p11).

The Atelier found that the letters on a pencil mean nothing in particular, because no standard sits behind them (p6). The activity study that covered 3.2 million adolescents reached us without a single confidence interval (p12). Gardens by the Bay says ticket prices will be released soon, for the fifth issue running (p23). And in China, every producer of an AI cartoon drama is paid by a coefficient that only the platform can see, and that it can change after the work is made (p26).

A withheld number is rarely a lie. It is usually just a decision about who gets to do the arithmetic. Sometimes, as on page ten, you can do it yourself.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

MERIDIAN · No. 157 · 9 November 2026

A note on method. Read at source this edition: Phillips' own lot results, parsed in full; the United States Treasury's daily par and real yield curves; the Bureau of Labor Statistics' October employment release; the Federal Register's text of the export-control stay; the *Resmî Gazete* of 9 November; two Consumer Product Safety Commission recalls; Raspberry Pi's and Home Assistant's release posts; a merged llama.cpp pull request; M1's breach notice; Audio-Technica's Japanese product page; Box Office Mojo and The Numbers; four journals' deposited records; the World Health Organization's activity report page; India's own e-visa fee schedule, downloaded as a document; Mitsubishi Pencil's and Caran d'Ache's factory pages; California Cedar's slat disclosures; Kabukiza's production pages; and five Chinese business outlets on the *mànjù* trade. **Refused this desk: Reddit entirely, across every desk in this issue, for the second consecutive edition; also Reuters, the Associated Press, the Guardian, the BBC, Channel NewsAsia, The Straits Times, every Penske-owned trade title, Billboard, The Lancet, TripAdvisor across four domains, Fodor's, UKClimbing, REI, Backcountry, Petzl's own product pages, JetPens, Burpple, SETHLUI, Time Out Singapore, the Michelin listings, Esplanade, SISTIC, Marina Bay Sands, Ticketmaster, Israel's presidency, Singapore's home affairs and education ministries, and China's broadcasting regulator. Where a source refused, this book says so on the page rather than borrowing someone else's summary.**